GRADUATE LECTURE NOTES

Advanced Quantum Mechanics

Faithful English Translation

Working Edition

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List of Notation

The following symbols are used in the present lecture notes. An operator carries a hat when it is written in abstract form; its matrix in a chosen basis may be written without a hat. Context distinguishes scalar coordinates from the corresponding operators.

Symbol	Meaning
States and Hilbert-space notation	
$\|a\rangle$, $\langle a\|$	Ket representing a state vector, and its Hermitian-adjoint bra.
$\|n\rangle$, $\langle n\|$	Basis ket and bra; indices label basis states.
$\langle a\|b\rangle$	Inner product of two state vectors.
$\langle a\|\hat{F}\|b\rangle$	Matrix element of operator $\hat{F}$.
$a_n = \langle n\|a\rangle$	Component of $\|a\rangle$ in the basis $\{\|n\rangle\}$.
$\sum_n \|n\rangle\langle n\| = \mathbf{1}$	Completeness relation for a discrete orthonormal basis.
δ_{mn}	Kronecker delta: 1 when $m = n$, otherwise 0.
Operators, observables, and transformations	
$\hat{F}$, $\hat{T}$	Abstract operators; F and T also denote matrix representations.
$\hat{F}^\dagger$, $F^\dagger$	Hermitian adjoint of an operator or matrix.
λ, f_n	An eigenvalue; f_n is an eigenvalue of observable $\hat{F}$.
$\langle F\rangle$	Expectation value of the observable $\hat{F}$.
ΔF	Fluctuation of a quantity about its expectation value, as defined in context.
$[A, B] = AB - BA$	Commutator of two operators or matrices.
$\{A, B\} = AB + BA$	Anticommutator.
$S_{im} = \langle i\|m\rangle$	Matrix connecting the I and M bases in Chapter 1.
$S^\dagger = S^{-1}$	Unitarity of the representation-transformation matrix S.
$\mathrm{tr}(T)$	Trace of a matrix or operator where defined.
Position, momentum, and physical constants	
$\|x\rangle$, $\|p\rangle$	Position and momentum eigenkets in one dimension.
$\boldsymbol{x}$, $\boldsymbol{p}$	Position and momentum vectors in three dimensions.
$\hat{x}_i$, $\hat{p}_j$	Cartesian components of the position and momentum operators.
$\psi(x) = \langle x\|\psi\rangle$	Wavefunction in the position representation.
$\delta(x - x')$, $\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x} - \boldsymbol{x}')$	Dirac delta distributions in one and three dimensions.
$\hbar$	Reduced Planck constant.
i	Imaginary unit, $\mathrm{i}^2 = -1$.
$\mathrm{d}x$, d^3x	One- and three-dimensional integration elements.
$\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})$	Operator effecting an infinitesimal spatial translation.
$\langle \boldsymbol{x}\|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle$	Position–momentum overlap, with Fourier normalization $(2\pi\hbar)^{-3/2}$.
Spin and Stern–Gerlach notation	
s_x, s_y, s_z	Components of spin angular momentum.
$\boldsymbol{J}$, $\boldsymbol{M}$, $\boldsymbol{B}$	Angular momentum, magnetic moment, and magnetic field.
$\boldsymbol{e}_i$	Unit vector along a coordinate axis.
Time evolution and the two pictures (Chapter 2)	
$\hat{U}(t, t_0)$	Unitary time-evolution operator from t_0 to t.
$\hat{H}$, E, ω	Hamiltonian, energy eigenvalue and angular frequency.
$\|\alpha, t\rangle$	Quantum state at time t in the Schrödinger picture.

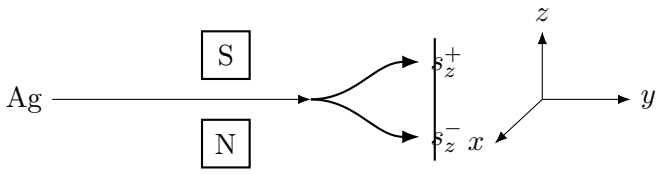
Symbol	Meaning (continued)
$\hat{A}_{\mathrm{S}}$, $\hat{A}_{\mathrm{H}}(t)$	Schrödinger- and Heisenberg-picture observable.
$\{A, H\}_{\mathrm{Poisson}}$	Classical Poisson bracket; distinct from a quantum anticommutator.
ΔA	Standard deviation of the observable $\hat{A}$.
Oscillator, semiclassical theory and propagation	
$\hat{a}$, $\hat{a}^\dagger$	Oscillator annihilation and creation operators.
$\hat{N} = \hat{a}^\dagger \hat{a}$	Number operator; $n = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$ labels number eigenstates.
$\lvert\alpha\rangle$	Coherent state, with $\hat{a}\lvert\alpha\rangle = \alpha\lvert\alpha\rangle$.
$\psi(\boldsymbol{x}, t)$, $\varphi_E(\boldsymbol{x})$	Coordinate-space wavefunction and stationary spatial eigenfunction.
$\rho(\boldsymbol{x}, t)$, $\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{x}, t)$	Probability density and probability-current density.
s_0, s_1, $p(x)$	WKB phase coefficients and local classical momentum.
$K(x_f, t_f; x_i, t_i)$	Propagator or position-space transition amplitude.
$S[x(t)]$, L_c	Classical action functional and Lagrangian.
Electromagnetism, geometric phases and monopoles	
φ, $\boldsymbol{A}$	Scalar and vector electromagnetic potentials.
$\boldsymbol{E}$, $\boldsymbol{B}$	Electric and magnetic fields in the source's Gaussian convention.
e, c	Signed charge and speed of light; factors $1/c$ follow the source convention.
$\Lambda(\boldsymbol{x})$	Scalar function generating a spatial gauge transformation.
ρ_a, ρ_b	Inner and outer radii of the cylindrical AB geometry.
e_m	Magnetic monopole charge, defined by $\boldsymbol{B} = e_m \boldsymbol{e}_r / r^2$.

Chapter 1

Basic Concepts

1.1 Stern–Gerlach Experiment

- The fundamental difference from classical mechanics is readily demonstrated.
- The central issue of quantum mechanics—the measurement problem—is readily demonstrated.
- A two-level system is the most quantum-mechanical system.



1) Results

A heated beam of silver atoms splits into two beams after passing through an inhomogeneous magnetic field.

2) Analysis

- The splitting is caused by interaction with the magnetic field and must therefore be due to the magnetic moment $\boldsymbol{M}$ of the atoms. The interaction potential is $V = -\boldsymbol{M} \cdot \boldsymbol{B}$.
- The magnetic moment is proportional to the angular momentum $\boldsymbol{J}$: $\boldsymbol{M} \propto \boldsymbol{J}$.
- The force on the atoms is

$$\boldsymbol{F} = -\boldsymbol{\nabla} V = M_z \frac{\partial B_z}{\partial z} \boldsymbol{e}_z \propto J_z \frac{\partial B_z}{\partial z} \boldsymbol{e}_z.$$

The beam separates symmetrically into an upper and a lower component. This indicates that the angular momentum along the direction of the magnetic field (the z direction) has only two components of equal magnitude and opposite directions.

If this angular momentum were produced by the rotation of the atoms themselves, the angular-momentum directions of the thermal atoms would be randomly distributed. After a large number of atoms passed through the magnetic field, their distribution on the screen would be symmetric and continuous, rather than consisting of two separated components. Thus the force does not originate from orbital angular momentum.

A silver atom has 47 electrons. Of these, 46 occupy filled shells with a spherically symmetric distribution and have no net angular momentum. The angular momentum of the silver atom is entirely due to the remaining valence electron. The separated two-component distribution shows that it is caused by the intrinsic angular momentum of the valence electron, denoted by

$\boldsymbol{s}$. The component s_z has only two values of equal magnitude and opposite direction, s_z^+ and s_z^-.

3) Quantum properties

- Spin angular momentum exists as an intrinsic physical quantity (independent of space and time).
- The values of spin angular momentum are discrete.
- The magnetic field performs a measurement. A magnetic field in the z direction measures the angular momentum in the z direction.

4) Cascaded Stern–Gerlach experiments

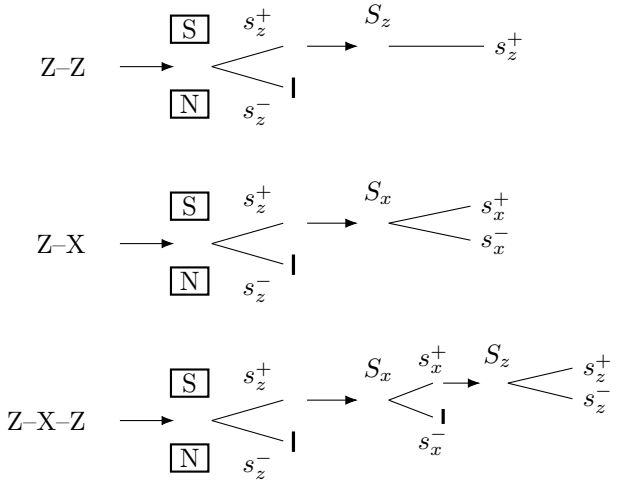


Figure 1.

The incident atomic beam passes successively through two magnetic fields in the z direction, as shown in the upper part of Fig. 1. Before the second magnetic field, s_z has the definite value s_z^+. Therefore the force on the atoms in that field is definite, and s_z still has the definite value s_z^+ after the second field.

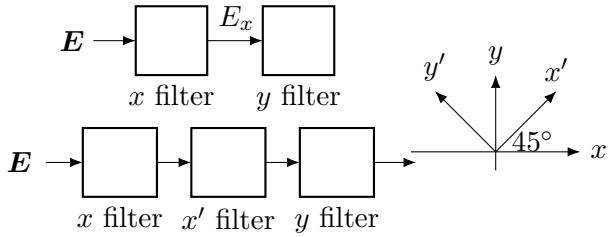
Now let the incident atomic beam pass through two magnetic fields, in the z and x directions, as shown in the middle of Fig. 1. In the second magnetic field the atoms experience a force $\boldsymbol{F} \propto J_x(\partial B_x/\partial x)\boldsymbol{e}_x$. The beam splits after the second magnetic field, indicating that s_x has two components s_x^+ and s_x^- before that field, although s_z has the definite value s_z^+.

- Quantum property: when s_z has a definite value, s_x does not. s_z and s_x cannot have definite values simultaneously.

Next, let the beam pass successively through three magnetic fields in the z, x, and z directions, as shown in the lower part of Fig. 1. Finally one observes two components s_z^+ and s_z^-. Thus s_z has two components before the third magnetic field, even though s_x has the definite value s_x^+.

- Quantum property: when s_x has a definite value, s_z likewise does not. s_x and s_z cannot have definite values simultaneously.

5) Analogy with classical electromagnetic waves (matter particles and light waves)



An electromagnetic wave propagating along the z direction disappears completely after passing successively through a filter that transmits only the x component (x filter) and a filter that transmits only the y component (y filter):

$$\begin{aligned} & \boldsymbol{E}(\boldsymbol{r},t) = E_0(\boldsymbol{e}_x + \boldsymbol{e}_y)\cos(kz-\omega t), \\ \xrightarrow{x \text{ filter}} \quad & E_0\boldsymbol{e}_x \cos(kz-\omega t), \\ \xrightarrow{y \text{ filter}} \quad & 0. \end{aligned}$$

Place an x' filter between the x and y filters, with x' at 45° to both x and y. An electromagnetic wave in the y direction can still be observed at the end:

$$\begin{aligned} & \boldsymbol{E}(\boldsymbol{r},t) = E_0(\boldsymbol{e}_x + \boldsymbol{e}_y)\cos(kz-\omega t), \\ \xrightarrow{x \text{ filter}} \quad & E_0\boldsymbol{e}_x \cos(kz-\omega t) = \frac{E_0}{\sqrt{2}}(\boldsymbol{e}_{x'} - \boldsymbol{e}_{y'})\cos(kz-\omega t), \\ \xrightarrow{x' \text{ filter}} \quad & \frac{E_0}{\sqrt{2}}\boldsymbol{e}_{x'}\cos(kz-\omega t) = \frac{E_0}{2}(\boldsymbol{e}_x + \boldsymbol{e}_y)\cos(kz-\omega t), \\ \xrightarrow{y \text{ filter}} \quad & \frac{E_0}{2}\boldsymbol{e}_y \cos(kz-\omega t). \end{aligned}$$

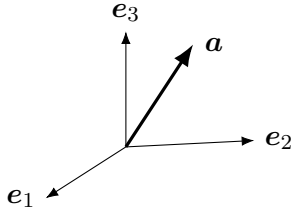
Similarity: s_x, s_y, s_z and $E_{x'}, E_{y'}$ can all be regarded as two-component vectors.

Difference: $\boldsymbol{s}$ is intrinsic angular momentum, a quantum-mechanical quantity; $\boldsymbol{E}$ is a spatially dependent mechanical quantity, a classical-mechanical quantity.

1.2 Linear Vector Spaces

From the preceding section, the projection s_n of the electron's spin angular momentum along any direction n can take only two values. We may regard s_n as a two-dimensional vector. To establish the mathematical description of quantum mechanics, we first discuss linear vector spaces.

1) Three-dimensional vector space



Arbitrary vector: $\boldsymbol{a}$.

Basis vectors: $\boldsymbol{e}_n$, $n = 1, 2, 3$.

Completeness of the basis:

$$\boldsymbol{a} = \sum_{n=1}^{3} a_n \boldsymbol{e}_n.$$

Inner product:

$$\boldsymbol{a} \cdot \boldsymbol{b} = \sum_{n,m} a_n b_m \boldsymbol{e}_n \cdot \boldsymbol{e}_m.$$

Squared norm of a vector: $\boldsymbol{a} \cdot \boldsymbol{a} \geq 0$.

If the basis vectors are orthonormal, $\boldsymbol{e}_n \cdot \boldsymbol{e}_m = \delta_{nm}$, the inner product has the matrix form

$$\boldsymbol{a} \cdot \boldsymbol{b} = \sum_{n} a_n b_n = \widetilde{a}\, b, \quad b = \begin{pmatrix} b_1 \\ b_2 \\ b_3 \end{pmatrix}, \quad a = \begin{pmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \\ a_3 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \widetilde{a} = (a_1, a_2, a_3),$$

where $\widetilde{a}$ is the transpose of a.

Components (matrix elements) of a vector:

$$a_n = \boldsymbol{e}_n \cdot \boldsymbol{a}.$$

The vector $\boldsymbol{a}$ is its abstract or general form. The matrix a is the representation of $\boldsymbol{a}$ in a specific coordinate system (representation). Its matrix elements depend on the choice of basis vectors; for example, Cartesian and spherical coordinate systems give different representations.

Operations on a vector, such as translations and rotations (operators), give another vector in the same three-dimensional space: $\hat{T}\boldsymbol{a} = \boldsymbol{b}$.

2) Hilbert space

Extend the three-dimensional vector space to a complex vector space of arbitrary dimension:

$$\text{three dimensions} \longrightarrow \text{arbitrary finite, infinite, or continuous dimension,}$$

$$\text{constant vectors} \longrightarrow \text{complex-function vectors.}$$

Use Dirac notation (a ket) to denote an arbitrary vector: $|a\rangle$.

For a complex vector, introduce the bra $\langle a|$ to represent its complex-conjugate vector. The bra and ket are not independent; they are conjugate to each other:

$$|a\rangle \longleftrightarrow \langle a| .$$

A vector can be represented by either a ket $|a\rangle$ or a bra $\langle a|$.

In a complex-function vector space, constants are generally complex, so

$$\alpha\, |a\rangle \longleftrightarrow \langle a|\, \alpha^*.$$

For an operation (operator) $\hat{T}$ in the complex space,

$$\hat{T}\, |a\rangle \longleftrightarrow \langle a|\, \hat{T}^\dagger.$$

$\hat{T}^\dagger$ is the left operator corresponding to the right operator $\hat{T}$, called the Hermitian-conjugate operator. Note that

$$\hat{T}\hat{F}\, |a\rangle = \hat{T}(\hat{F}\, |a\rangle) \longleftrightarrow \langle a|\, \hat{F}^\dagger \hat{T}^\dagger.$$

We now choose a particular representation, taking an N-dimensional discrete space as an example.

Basis vectors: $|n\rangle$, $n = 1, 2, \ldots$.

Expansion in a complete basis (concrete representation of a vector):

$$|a\rangle = \sum_n a_n |n\rangle , \qquad \langle a| = \sum_n a_n^* \langle n| .$$

Inner product:

$$\langle a|b\rangle = \sum_{n,m} a_n^* b_m \langle n|m\rangle ,$$

which is a complex number.

Squared norm: $\langle a|a\rangle \geq 0$. (Only when $|a\rangle$ and $\langle a|$ are defined as conjugates can the squared norm be guaranteed nonnegative.)

Normalized vector: defining $|\widetilde{a}\rangle = |a\rangle / \sqrt{\langle a|a\rangle}$ gives $\langle \widetilde{a}|\widetilde{a}\rangle = 1$; the vector is said to be normalized.

Orthonormality of basis vectors: $\langle n|m\rangle = \delta_{nm}$.

Matrix form of the inner product:

$$\langle a|b\rangle = \sum_n a_n^* b_n = a^\dagger b, \qquad b = \begin{pmatrix} b_1 \\ b_2 \\ \vdots \\ b_N \end{pmatrix}, \quad a = \begin{pmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \\ \vdots \\ a_N \end{pmatrix},$$

where the Hermitian conjugate (complex-conjugate transpose) of the column matrix a is the row matrix

$$a^\dagger = (a_1^*, a_2^*, \ldots, a_N^*).$$

Evidently,

$$\langle a|b\rangle = \langle b|a\rangle^* , \qquad \left\langle a\middle|\hat{T}\middle|b\right\rangle = \left\langle b\middle|\hat{T}^\dagger\middle|a\right\rangle^* .$$

Components (matrix elements) of a vector: multiplying $|a\rangle = \sum_n a_n |n\rangle$ from the left by $\langle m|$ gives

$$a_m = \langle m|a\rangle .$$

Completeness of the basis:

$$|a\rangle = \sum_n a_n |n\rangle = \sum_n |n\rangle \langle n|a\rangle = \left(\sum_n |n\rangle \langle n| \right) |a\rangle .$$

Because $|a\rangle$ is arbitrary,

$$\boxed{\sum_n |n\rangle \langle n| = \mathbf{1}},$$

which is the completeness relation for the basis.

Representation of an operator (matrix form). Let $|b\rangle = \hat{F}|a\rangle$. Then

$$\langle m|b\rangle = \left\langle m\middle|\hat{F}\middle|a\right\rangle = \sum_n \left\langle m\middle|\hat{F}\middle|n\right\rangle \langle n|a\rangle , \qquad F_{mn} = \left\langle m\middle|\hat{F}\middle|n\right\rangle ,$$

and therefore

$$b_m = \sum_n F_{mn} a_n .$$

In matrix form, $b = Fa$. The matrix F represents the operator $\hat{F}$; it is a square matrix with elements F_{mn}.

Representation of the Hermitian-conjugate operator (left operator). From $\langle b| = \langle a|\hat{F}^\dagger$,

$$\langle b|m\rangle = \left\langle a\middle|\hat{F}^\dagger\middle|m\right\rangle = \sum_n \langle a|n\rangle \left\langle n\middle|\hat{F}^\dagger\middle|m\right\rangle,$$

so

$$b_m^* = \sum_n (F^\dagger)_{nm} a_n^*, \qquad b_m = \sum_n [(F^\dagger)_{nm}]^* a_n.$$

Comparison yields

$$[(F^\dagger)_{nm}]^* = F_{mn}, \qquad (F^\dagger)_{nm} = F_{mn}^*, \qquad F^\dagger = (\widetilde{F})^*.$$

Thus $F^\dagger$ is the Hermitian-conjugate matrix of F.

Outer product. The outer product is $|a\rangle\langle b|$.

Its representation is a square matrix (a is a column matrix and $b^\dagger$ a row matrix), so the outer product is an operator. In fact,

$$(|a\rangle\langle b|)|c\rangle = |a\rangle(\langle b|c\rangle),$$

showing that $|a\rangle\langle b|$ maps $|c\rangle$ to another vector parallel to $|a\rangle$. Hence $|a\rangle\langle b|$ is indeed an operator. Its representation is a square matrix with elements

$$(|a\rangle\langle b|)_{mn} = \langle m||a\rangle\langle b||n\rangle = \langle m|a\rangle\langle b|n\rangle = a_m b_n^*.$$

1.3 Eigenvalues and Eigenvectors of Operators (Matrices)

1) Eigenvalues and eigenstates of a general operator

The eigenvalue equation of an operator is

$$\hat{T}|a\rangle = \lambda|a\rangle,$$

where λ is called an eigenvalue of $\hat{T}$ and $|a\rangle$ is called an eigenvector of $\hat{T}$.

In matrix form (prove this yourself using the completeness relation),

$$Ta = \lambda a, \qquad (T - \lambda I)a = 0.$$

The condition for a nonzero eigenvector $a \neq 0$ is

$$\det(T - \lambda I) = 0.$$

This is the secular equation in an N-dimensional space:

$$\begin{vmatrix} T_{11}-\lambda & T_{12} & \cdots & T_{1N} \\ T_{21} & T_{22}-\lambda & \cdots & T_{2N} \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ T_{N1} & T_{N2} & \cdots & T_{NN}-\lambda \end{vmatrix} = 0.$$

One thereby obtains N eigenvalues λ_i $(i = 1, 2, \ldots, N)$. Substituting each into

$$(T - \lambda_i I)a = 0$$

gives the corresponding eigenvector a.

Example. Find the eigenvalues and eigenvectors of

$$T = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The secular equation is

$$\begin{vmatrix} 1-\lambda & 0 \\ 0 & -1-\lambda \end{vmatrix} = 0, \quad \text{i.e.,} \quad \lambda^2 - 1 = 0,$$

and the eigenvalues are $\lambda_\pm = \pm 1$.

Let $a = (a_1, a_2)^\mathsf{T}$. For $\lambda = 1$,

$$\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -2 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{pmatrix} = 0.$$

The normalized eigenvector is $a = (1, 0)^\mathsf{T}$. Similarly, taking $\lambda = -1$ gives $a = (0, 1)^\mathsf{T}$.

2) Hermitian operators

If $\hat{T}^\dagger = \hat{T}$, or $T^\dagger = T$, the operator $\hat{T}$ is called Hermitian and T is called a Hermitian matrix.

We discuss the following properties of Hermitian operators.

a) Conjugate symmetry.

$$\left\langle a \middle| \hat{T} \middle| b \right\rangle = \left\langle b \middle| \hat{T}^\dagger \middle| a \right\rangle^* = \left\langle b \middle| \hat{T} \middle| a \right\rangle^*.$$

In particular,

$$\left\langle a \middle| \hat{T} \middle| a \right\rangle = \left\langle a \middle| \hat{T} \middle| a \right\rangle^*,$$

which shows that the expectation value $\left\langle a \middle| \hat{T} \middle| a \right\rangle$ of a Hermitian operator is real.

For an anti-Hermitian operator, $\hat{T}^\dagger = -\hat{T}$ and

$$\left\langle a \middle| \hat{T} \middle| a \right\rangle = -\left\langle a \middle| \hat{T} \middle| a \right\rangle^*,$$

so its expectation value is purely imaginary.

b) Reality of eigenvalues and orthogonality.

Suppose

$$\hat{T}\,|i\rangle = \lambda_i\,|i\rangle\,, \qquad \hat{T}\,|j\rangle = \lambda_j\,|j\rangle\,.$$

From

$$\left\langle j \middle| \hat{T} \middle| i \right\rangle = \lambda_i\,\langle j|i\rangle$$

and

$$\langle j|\,\hat{T} = \langle j|\,\lambda_j^*, \qquad \left\langle j \middle| \hat{T} \middle| i \right\rangle = \lambda_j^*\,\langle j|i\rangle\,,$$

we obtain

$$(\lambda_i - \lambda_j^*)\,\langle j|i\rangle = 0.$$

For $j = i$ and $\langle i|i\rangle \neq 0$, $\lambda_i = \lambda_i^*$: the eigenvalues of a Hermitian operator are real.

For $j \neq i$, if $\lambda_i - \lambda_j \neq 0$, then $\langle j|i\rangle = 0$. Thus eigenstates corresponding to different eigenvalues of a Hermitian operator are orthogonal. Since they can always be normalized, the orthonormality condition is

$$\langle i|j\rangle = \delta_{ij}.$$

Question: Are eigenstates corresponding to the same eigenvalue orthogonal?

c) Orthogonalization by linear superposition (Schmidt orthogonalization). Suppose several eigenstates correspond to the same eigenvalue, i.e., there is degeneracy. For example, for a g-fold degenerate eigenvalue ($g \geq 2$),

$$\hat{T}\,|i,j\rangle = \lambda_i\,|i,j\rangle\,, \qquad j = 1,\ldots,g.$$

Are these g eigenvectors orthogonal?

Redefine g new states:

$$|i,n\rangle = \sum_{j=1}^{g} C_{nj}\,|i,j\rangle\,, \qquad n = 1,2,\ldots,g.$$

Since

$$\hat{T}\,|i,n\rangle = \sum_{j=1}^{g} C_{nj}\hat{T}\,|i,j\rangle = \lambda_i \sum_{j=1}^{g} C_{nj}\,|i,j\rangle = \lambda_i\,|i,n\rangle\,,$$

each $|i,n\rangle$ is still an eigenstate of $\hat{T}$ with eigenvalue λ_i. Hence it suffices to show that the $|i,n\rangle$ can be made orthonormal.

Can one choose the coefficients C_{nj} so that these g new states satisfy

$$\langle i,m|i,n\rangle = \delta_{mn}\ ?$$

There are g normalization equations and $(g^2-g)/2$ orthogonality equations, making $g(g+1)/2$ independent equations, fewer than the g^2 coefficients C_{nj}. Thus there are various choices of coefficients satisfying the orthonormality conditions, so that the new states $|i,n\rangle$ are orthonormal:

$$\langle i,m|j,n\rangle = \delta_{ij}\delta_{mn}.$$

Here δ_{ij} follows from orthonormality of eigenstates belonging to different eigenvalues, while δ_{mn} follows from orthogonalization by linear superposition.

Conclusion: Eigenstates of a Hermitian operator can be chosen orthonormal, whether the eigenvalues are degenerate or nondegenerate.

d) Completeness. It can be shown that eigenvectors of a Hermitian operator satisfy

$$\sum_i |i\rangle\,\langle i| = \mathbf{1}.$$

Hence the eigenvectors of a Hermitian operator can form a set of orthonormal basis vectors of a Hilbert space, i.e., a linear vector space or a representation.

1.4 Measurement

We discuss the connection between quantum mechanics and Hilbert space.

1) Measurement of a single physical quantity

In the Stern–Gerlach experiment, s_z has no definite value before the magnetic field (if it did, only one beam of silver atoms would emerge). It has a definite value only after the field: one beam has s_z^+, and the other has s_z^-. Therefore the values of quantum-mechanical quantities are closely related to the state of the system. A physical quantity has no definite value in a general state; it has a definite value only in certain particular states.

Postulate of quantum mechanics: Physical quantities of a quantum-mechanical system are represented by Hermitian operators in a linear vector space, and states are represented by

vectors. Because the eigenstates of a Hermitian operator are complete, the eigenstates of any physical quantity can form a linear vector space, or a representation.

The eigenvalue equation of $\hat{F}$ is

$$\hat{F}\left|n\right\rangle = f_n \left|n\right\rangle .$$

In the F representation, the basis vectors are $|n\rangle$. An arbitrary state is

$$\left|a\right\rangle = \sum_n \left|n\right\rangle \left\langle n|a\right\rangle .$$

The coefficient $\langle n|a\rangle$ is the concrete representation of $|a\rangle$ in the F representation.

Postulate of quantum mechanics: The physical quantity $\hat{F}$ has a definite value, namely the eigenvalue f_n, only in its eigenstate $|n\rangle$. In an arbitrary state $|a\rangle$, $\hat{F}$ has no definite value, but has a definite average value

$$\langle F\rangle \equiv \left\langle a\middle|\hat{F}\middle|a\right\rangle .$$

(The eigenvalues and expectation values of Hermitian operators are real. This is why physical quantities are represented by Hermitian operators.)

$$\begin{aligned}\langle F\rangle \equiv \left\langle a\middle|\hat{F}\middle|a\right\rangle &= \sum_{n,m} \left\langle a|n\right\rangle \left\langle n\middle|\hat{F}\middle|m\right\rangle \left\langle m|a\right\rangle \\ &= \sum_{n,m} \left\langle a|n\right\rangle f_m \delta_{nm} \left\langle m|a\right\rangle = \sum_n \left\langle a|n\right\rangle \left\langle n|a\right\rangle f_n = \sum_n |\left\langle n|a\right\rangle|^2 f_n .\end{aligned}$$

Thus the probability that $\hat{F}$ takes the value f_n is $|\langle n|a\rangle|^2$. The quantity $\langle n|a\rangle$ is a probability amplitude, and $|\langle n|a\rangle|^2$ is the probability for state $|a\rangle$ to contain state $|n\rangle$.

In a general state, the value of a physical quantity is uncertain, but its probabilities and expectation value are definite.

In the eigenbasis of $\hat{F}$, the matrix elements are

$$F_{mn} = \left\langle m\middle|\hat{F}\middle|n\right\rangle = f_n \left\langle m|n\right\rangle = f_n \delta_{mn}.$$

Thus a physical quantity is represented by a diagonal matrix in its own representation, and the diagonal elements are its eigenvalues.

We now discuss measurement and collapse of the state.

Before the magnetic field in the Stern–Gerlach experiment, s_z of an Ag atom has no definite value; after passing through the field it has a definite value. Applying the magnetic field can be regarded as measuring the spin. Once measured, it has a definite value.

When $\hat{F}$ is measured in an arbitrary state $|a\rangle$, the system collapses into an eigenstate of $\hat{F}$, so $\hat{F}$ has a definite value. Which eigenstate does it collapse into? The probability for state $|a\rangle$ to contain state $|n\rangle$ is $|\langle n|a\rangle|^2$. Therefore the probability of collapse into $|n\rangle$, i.e., of obtaining the measurement value f_n, is $|\langle n|a\rangle|^2$.

Measurement allows the particle nature of the system to become manifest; one may also say that measurement produces a particle.

Question: Measure $\hat{F}$ in state $|a\rangle$ and obtain f_n. If $\hat{F}$ is measured again immediately, what value will be obtained?

First measurement: $|a\rangle \longrightarrow |n\rangle$.

At the second measurement, the system is already in the eigenstate $|n\rangle$ of $\hat{F}$; the result is still f_n. This explains why an Ag atom in the Stern–Gerlach experiment still has spin s_z^+ after passing through two magnetic fields in the z direction.

2) Spin matrices

From the Stern–Gerlach experiment, the electron has spin 1/2, and the spin operator $\hat{\boldsymbol{s}}\cdot\boldsymbol{e}_n = \hat{s}_n$ along any direction $\boldsymbol{e}_n$ takes the values $\pm\hbar/2$. Its eigenvalue equation is

$$\hat{s}_n \left|s_n^{\pm}\right\rangle = \pm\frac{\hbar}{2}\left|s_n^{\pm}\right\rangle .$$

In the representation formed by the eigenstates of $\hat{s}_z$ (the s_z representation), s_z is a diagonal matrix whose diagonal entries are $\pm\hbar/2$:

$$s_z = \frac{\hbar}{2}\begin{pmatrix}1 & 0\\ 0 & -1\end{pmatrix}.$$

Solving

$$s_z\begin{pmatrix}a\\ b\end{pmatrix} = \pm\frac{\hbar}{2}\begin{pmatrix}a\\ b\end{pmatrix}$$

gives the normalized eigenstates

$$\left|s_z^{+}\right\rangle = \begin{pmatrix}1\\ 0\end{pmatrix}, \qquad \left|s_z^{-}\right\rangle = \begin{pmatrix}0\\ 1\end{pmatrix}.$$

We now find the matrices for $\hat{s}_x$ and $\hat{s}_y$ in the s_z representation. From the completeness of the eigenstates of $\hat{s}_z$,

$$\left|s_x^{+}\right\rangle = \sum_{i=\pm}\left|s_z^{i}\right\rangle\left\langle s_z^{i}\middle|s_x^{+}\right\rangle = \left\langle s_z^{+}\middle|s_x^{+}\right\rangle\left|s_z^{+}\right\rangle + \left\langle s_z^{-}\middle|s_x^{+}\right\rangle\left|s_z^{-}\right\rangle .$$

The cascaded Stern–Gerlach experiment shows that a state with a definite s_x value, after passing through a z-directed magnetic field (a measurement device for s_z), separates into two beams of equal intensity, with equal probabilities for s_z^+ and s_z^-:

$$\left|\left\langle s_z^{+}\middle|s_x^{+}\right\rangle\right| = \left|\left\langle s_z^{-}\middle|s_x^{+}\right\rangle\right| = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}.$$

Consequently,

$$\left|s_x^{+}\right\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\left|s_z^{+}\right\rangle + \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}e^{\mathrm{i}\delta_1}\left|s_z^{-}\right\rangle .$$

Through normalization, the phase factors have been collected into δ_1.

Using the orthonormality of $|s_x^{\pm}\rangle$, $\langle s_x^i|s_x^j\rangle = \delta_{ij}$, we obtain

$$\left|s_x^{-}\right\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\left|s_z^{+}\right\rangle - \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}e^{\mathrm{i}\delta_1}\left|s_z^{-}\right\rangle .$$

Equivalently,

$$\begin{cases}\left|s_z^{+}\right\rangle = \dfrac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(\left|s_x^{+}\right\rangle + \left|s_x^{-}\right\rangle),\\ \left|s_z^{-}\right\rangle = \dfrac{1}{\sqrt{2}}e^{-\mathrm{i}\delta_1}(\left|s_x^{+}\right\rangle - \left|s_x^{-}\right\rangle).\end{cases}$$

Substituting into the matrix elements of $\hat{s}_x$ gives

$$\left\langle s_z^{+}\middle|\hat{s}_x\middle|s_z^{+}\right\rangle = 0, \quad \left\langle s_z^{+}\middle|\hat{s}_x\middle|s_z^{-}\right\rangle = \frac{\hbar}{2}e^{-\mathrm{i}\delta_1}, \quad \left\langle s_z^{-}\middle|\hat{s}_x\middle|s_z^{+}\right\rangle = \frac{\hbar}{2}e^{\mathrm{i}\delta_1}, \quad \langle s_z^{-}|\hat{s}_x|s_z^{-}\rangle = 0.$$

Thus

$$s_x = \frac{\hbar}{2}\begin{pmatrix}0 & e^{-\mathrm{i}\delta_1}\\ e^{\mathrm{i}\delta_1} & 0\end{pmatrix}.$$

Similarly,

$$\left|s_y^{\pm}\right\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\left|s_z^{+}\right\rangle \pm \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}e^{\mathrm{i}\delta_2}\left|s_z^{-}\right\rangle, \qquad s_y = \frac{\hbar}{2}\begin{pmatrix} 0 & e^{-\mathrm{i}\delta_2} \\ e^{\mathrm{i}\delta_2} & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Now consider the values of δ_1, δ_2. A state with a definite s_x value, after passing through a magnetic field in the y direction (a measurement device for s_y), splits into two equally intense beams corresponding to s_y^+ and s_y^-:

$$|\left\langle s_y^{\pm}\middle|s_x^{+}\right\rangle| = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}.$$

That is,

$$\frac{1}{2}\left|1 \pm e^{\mathrm{i}(\delta_1-\delta_2)}\right| = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}.$$

Hence

$$\delta_1 - \delta_2 = \pm\frac{\pi}{2}.$$

Choosing $\delta_1 = 0$ and $\delta_2 = \pi/2$ yields

$$s_x = \frac{\hbar}{2}\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad s_y = \frac{\hbar}{2}\begin{pmatrix} 0 & -\mathrm{i} \\ \mathrm{i} & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

For s_x, s_y, s_z, one can show that

$$[s_i, s_j] = \mathrm{i}\epsilon_{ijk}\hbar s_k, \qquad \{s_i, s_j\} = \frac{\hbar^2}{2}\delta_{ij},$$

where

$$[A, B] = AB - BA, \qquad \{A, B\} = AB + BA.$$

Define

$$s^2 = \sum_i s_i^2 = \frac{3}{4}\hbar^2\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Because s^2 is proportional to the identity matrix, every state is its eigenstate, and it has the definite value $3\hbar^2/4$ in every state. Clearly, $\hat{s^2}$ commutes with every physical quantity $\hat{F}$ and may be regarded as a classical quantity.

3) Conditions for simultaneous measurement of several physical quantities

Can two physical quantities $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ be measured simultaneously?

Theorem. If $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ have a complete set of common eigenstates, then $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ commute.

Proof. Let the complete common eigenstates be $|n\rangle$, with

$$\hat{A}\left|n\right\rangle = a_n\left|n\right\rangle, \qquad \hat{B}\left|n\right\rangle = b_n\left|n\right\rangle.$$

In the representation formed by $|n\rangle$, an arbitrary state is

$$\left|\psi\right\rangle = \sum_n \left|n\right\rangle\left\langle n|\psi\right\rangle.$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned}(\hat{A}\hat{B} - \hat{B}\hat{A})\left|\psi\right\rangle &= \sum_n (\hat{A}\hat{B} - \hat{B}\hat{A})\left|n\right\rangle\left\langle n|\psi\right\rangle \\ &= \sum_n (\hat{A}b_n - \hat{B}a_n)\left|n\right\rangle\left\langle n|\psi\right\rangle \\ &= \sum_n (a_n b_n - b_n a_n)\left|n\right\rangle\left\langle n|\psi\right\rangle = 0.\end{aligned}$$

Since $|\psi\rangle$ is arbitrary, $[\hat{A}, \hat{B}] = 0$.

Converse theorem. If $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ commute, then they have a complete set of common eigenstates.

Proof. Let $|n\rangle$ be an eigenstate of $\hat{A}$:

$$\hat{A}\,|n\rangle = a_n\,|n\rangle\,.$$

From $[\hat{A}, \hat{B}] = 0$,

$$\hat{A}\hat{B}\,|n\rangle = \hat{B}\hat{A}\,|n\rangle = a_n\hat{B}\,|n\rangle\,.$$

Thus $\hat{B}\,|n\rangle$ is also an eigenstate of $\hat{A}$ with eigenvalue a_n. If $\hat{A}$ is nondegenerate, $\hat{B}\,|n\rangle$ and $|n\rangle$ are the same state up to a constant:

$$\hat{B}\,|n\rangle = b_n\,|n\rangle\,.$$

Therefore $|n\rangle$ is also an eigenstate of $\hat{B}$, and $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ have a complete common eigenbasis.

If $\hat{A}$ is degenerate, one can use the Schmidt method to prove the same result (exercise).

Conclusion. When several physical quantities commute, they can have common eigenstates. In those common eigenstates, all these quantities have definite values, and they can be measured simultaneously.

Note that $[\hat{A}, \hat{B}] = 0$ and $[\hat{B}, \hat{C}] = 0$ mean that A, B can have definite values simultaneously and that B, C can have definite values simultaneously. However, A, C need not have definite values simultaneously.

When $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ do not commute, they cannot have a complete set of common eigenstates and cannot always be measured simultaneously. They may, however, be simultaneously measurable in a subspace. For example, for orbital angular momentum,

$$[\hat{\boldsymbol{L}}^2, \hat{L}_x] = 0, \qquad [\hat{\boldsymbol{L}}^2, \hat{L}_y] = 0, \qquad [\hat{L}_x, \hat{L}_y] \neq 0.$$

Thus L^2, L_x can have definite values simultaneously, and L^2, L_y can have definite values simultaneously, while L_x, L_y cannot generally have definite values simultaneously. In the state with $L = 0$, however, L_x, L_y are simultaneously definite, with $L_x = L_y = 0$.

4) Complete set of physical quantities

When eigenvalues and eigenstates of a physical quantity are degenerate,

$$\hat{F}\,|i, j\rangle = f_i\,|i, j\rangle\,, \qquad j = 1, \ldots, g,$$

Schmidt orthogonalization can be used mathematically to obtain orthonormal eigenstates. In physics, however, one generally introduces a complete set of physical quantities to achieve orthonormality.

That several eigenstates share one eigenvalue indicates that this physical quantity is insufficient to characterize the states completely; another physical quantity is needed to distinguish them. Introduce $\hat{T}$ and require that the eigenstates of $\hat{F}$ also be eigenstates of $\hat{T}$:

$$\hat{F}\,|i, j\rangle = f_i\,|i, j\rangle\,, \qquad \hat{T}\,|i, j\rangle = t_j\,|i, j\rangle\,.$$

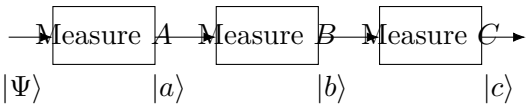
For the set $\{\hat{F}, \hat{T}\}$, if the pair of eigenvalues $\{f_i, t_j\}$ corresponds one-to-one to the eigenstate $|i, j\rangle$, there is no degeneracy, and the orthonormality condition is

$$\langle i, j|i', j'\rangle = \delta_{ii'}\delta_{jj'}.$$

5) Cascaded measurements

For three physical quantities $\hat{A}, \hat{B}, \hat{C}$, consider the following two measurement procedures.

First procedure:



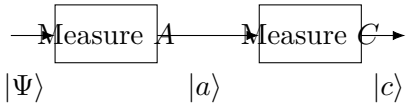
The state sequence is $|\Psi\rangle \to |a\rangle \to |b\rangle \to |c\rangle$; the values of the physical quantities are initially indefinite and then are a, b, c after their respective measurements.

After three measurements, the probability for $\hat{C}$ to take the value c is

$$P(c) = \sum_{a,b} |\langle a|\Psi\rangle|^2 |\langle b|a\rangle|^2 |\langle c|b\rangle|^2.$$

Here $|\langle a|\Psi\rangle|^2$ is the probability of collapse from $|\Psi\rangle$ to $|a\rangle$; $|\langle b|a\rangle|^2$ is the probability from $|a\rangle$ to $|b\rangle$; and $|\langle c|b\rangle|^2$ is the probability from $|b\rangle$ to $|c\rangle$.

Second procedure:



After two measurements, the probability for $\hat{C}$ to take the value c is

$$P'(c) = \sum_{a} |\langle a|\Psi\rangle|^2 |\langle c|a\rangle|^2.$$

Clearly, in general,

$$P(c) \neq P'(c).$$

However, if $[\hat{A}, \hat{B}] = 0$, $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ have common eigenstates $|n\rangle$, which replace $|a\rangle$ and $|b\rangle$:

$$P(c) = \sum_{n} |\langle n|\Psi\rangle|^2 |\langle c|n\rangle|^2 = P'(c).$$

Or if $[\hat{B}, \hat{C}] = 0$, $\hat{B}$ and $\hat{C}$ have common eigenstates $|m\rangle$, which replace $|b\rangle$ and $|c\rangle$:

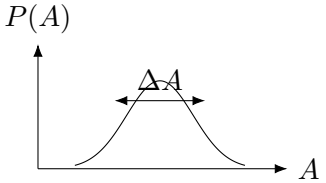
$$P(c) = \sum_{a} |\langle a|\Psi\rangle|^2 |\langle m|a\rangle|^2 = P'(c).$$

Conclusion. Since physical quantities have definite values only in their eigenstates, the order of measurements changes the final measurement results.

6) Uncertainty relation

If $[\hat{A}, \hat{B}] \neq 0$, the physical quantities $\hat{A}, \hat{B}$ cannot have definite values simultaneously. How large are their uncertainties?

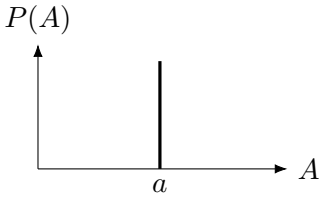
In an arbitrary state $|\psi\rangle$, $\hat{A}$ has only a definite expectation value $\langle \hat{A} \rangle \equiv \left\langle \psi \middle| \hat{A} \middle| \psi \right\rangle$ and a distribution $P(A)$.



The uncertainty is represented by the variance:

$$\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle \equiv \left\langle\psi\middle|(\hat{A}-\langle\hat{A}\rangle)^2\middle|\psi\right\rangle \geq 0.$$

If $|\psi\rangle$ is an eigenstate of $\hat{A}$, the expectation value equals its eigenvalue, the variance is zero, and the distribution is a delta function.



Define the uncertainty between $\hat{A}$ and $\hat{B}$ using the product of variances $\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle\langle(\Delta\hat{B})^2\rangle$. How can we estimate it?

For arbitrary states $|\alpha\rangle, |\beta\rangle$ and arbitrary complex number λ, the norm of the linear-combination state is nonnegative:

$$(\langle\alpha| + \lambda^* \langle\beta|)(|\alpha\rangle + \lambda|\beta\rangle) \geq 0.$$

Choosing

$$\lambda = -\frac{\langle\beta|\alpha\rangle}{\langle\beta|\beta\rangle}$$

gives the Schwarz inequality,

$$\langle\alpha|\alpha\rangle\ \langle\beta|\beta\rangle \geq |\langle\alpha|\beta\rangle|^2.$$

Set

$$|\alpha\rangle = \Delta\hat{A}|\Psi\rangle, \qquad |\beta\rangle = \Delta\hat{B}|\Psi\rangle, \qquad \Delta\hat{A} = \hat{A} - \langle\hat{A}\rangle, \quad \Delta\hat{B} = \hat{B} - \langle\hat{B}\rangle.$$

Then

$$\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle\langle(\Delta\hat{B})^2\rangle \geq |\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle|^2.$$

Since

$$\begin{aligned}|\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle|^2 &= (\mathrm{Re}\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle)^2 + (\mathrm{Im}\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle)^2 \\ &\geq (\mathrm{Im}\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle)^2 \\ &= \left[\frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}}\left(\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle - \langle\Delta\hat{B}\Delta\hat{A}\rangle\right)\right]^2,\end{aligned}$$

we obtain

$$\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle\langle(\Delta\hat{B})^2\rangle \geq \left[\frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}}\left(\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle - \langle\Delta\hat{B}\Delta\hat{A}\rangle\right)\right]^2.$$

Equality requires equality in the Schwarz inequality and a vanishing real part of $\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle$.

From

$$\begin{aligned}\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle &= \left\langle\psi\middle|(\hat{A}-\langle\hat{A}\rangle)(\hat{B}-\langle\hat{B}\rangle)\middle|\psi\right\rangle = \langle\hat{A}\hat{B}\rangle - \langle\hat{A}\rangle\langle\hat{B}\rangle, \\ \langle\Delta\hat{B}\Delta\hat{A}\rangle &= \left\langle\psi\middle|(\hat{B}-\langle\hat{B}\rangle)(\hat{A}-\langle\hat{A}\rangle)\middle|\psi\right\rangle = \langle\hat{B}\hat{A}\rangle - \langle\hat{B}\rangle\langle\hat{A}\rangle,\end{aligned}$$

it follows that

$$\boxed{\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle\langle(\Delta\hat{B})^2\rangle \geq \left(\frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}}\langle[\hat{A},\hat{B}]\rangle\right)^2.}$$

This shows that the uncertainties of two physical quantities are controlled by their commutation relation and the state $|\psi\rangle$.

1.5 Transformation of Representations

Selecting a suitable representation can simplify a calculation. The transformation between basis vectors of different representations is called a transformation of representation.

Consider two representations:

$$\begin{array}{ll} I \text{ representation:} & \text{basis } |i\rangle\,, \quad \hat{I}\,|i\rangle = i\,|i\rangle\,, \\ M \text{ representation:} & \text{basis } |m\rangle\,, \quad \hat{M}\,|m\rangle = m\,|m\rangle\,. \end{array}$$

We have

$$|m\rangle = \sum_i |i\rangle\,\langle i|m\rangle = \sum_i S_{im}\,|i\rangle\,.$$

The transformation matrix S is defined by

$$S_{im} = \langle i|m\rangle\,.$$

It represents the basis vectors of the M representation in the I representation.

1) Transformation of an arbitrary vector

In the I representation,

$$|a\rangle = \sum_i |i\rangle\,\langle i|a\rangle\,.$$

The coefficient $\langle i|a\rangle$ is the component of $|a\rangle$ along $|i\rangle$, or its representation in the I basis.

In the M representation,

$$|a\rangle = \sum_m |m\rangle\,\langle m|a\rangle\,.$$

The coefficient $\langle m|a\rangle$ is the component along $|m\rangle$, or the representation of $|a\rangle$ in the M basis.

Using completeness,

$$\langle m|a\rangle = \sum_i \langle m|i\rangle\,\langle i|a\rangle = \sum_i S^*_{im}\,\langle i|a\rangle = \sum_i S^\dagger_{mi}\,\langle i|a\rangle\,.$$

In matrix form,

$$\boxed{a_M = S^\dagger a_I.}$$

2) Transformation of an arbitrary operator

In the I representation,

$$(T_I)_{ij} = \left\langle i\middle|\hat{T}\middle|j\right\rangle.$$

In the M representation,

$$\begin{aligned}(T_M)_{mn} = \left\langle m\middle|\hat{T}\middle|n\right\rangle &= \sum_{ij} \langle m|i\rangle\left\langle i\middle|\hat{T}\middle|j\right\rangle\langle j|n\rangle \\ &= \sum_{ij} S^*_{im}(T_I)_{ij}S_{jn} = \sum_{ij}(S^\dagger)_{mi}(T_I)_{ij}S_{jn}.\end{aligned}$$

In matrix form,

$$\boxed{T_M = S^\dagger T_I S.}$$

3) The representation-transformation matrix is unitary

$$(SS^\dagger)_{ij} = \sum_m S_{im}(S^\dagger)_{mj} = \sum_m S_{im}S^*_{jm} = \sum_m \langle i|m\rangle \langle m|j\rangle = \langle i|j\rangle = \delta_{ij}.$$

Therefore $SS^\dagger = \mathbf{1}$. Similarly, $S^\dagger S = \mathbf{1}$, and hence

$$\boxed{S^\dagger = S^{-1}.}$$

A representation-transformation matrix is unitary.

Note that S is not necessarily Hermitian: $S^\dagger \neq S$.

4) Transformation of representation does not change eigenvalues

Suppose

$$T_I a_I = \lambda_I a_I.$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned} T_M a_M &= S^\dagger T_I S S^\dagger a_I = S^\dagger T_I a_I = S^\dagger \lambda_I a_I \\ &= \lambda_I S^\dagger a_I = \lambda_I a_M. \end{aligned}$$

Thus the eigenvalue in the M representation is still λ_I. A transformation of representation does not change the values of physical quantities.

Example 1: A transformation of representation does not change commutation relations.

If $[A_I, B_I] = C_I$ in the I representation, then in the M representation,

$$\begin{aligned} [A_M, B_M] &= A_M B_M - B_M A_M \\ &= S^\dagger A_I S S^\dagger B_I S - S^\dagger B_I S S^\dagger A_I S \\ &= S^\dagger (A_I B_I - B_I A_I) S = S^\dagger C_I S = C_M. \end{aligned}$$

Commutation relations are fundamental relations of quantum mechanics and are unchanged by the transformation of representation.

Example 2: A transformation of representation does not change the trace of a matrix:

$$\mathrm{tr}(T_M) = \mathrm{tr}(S^\dagger T_I S) = \mathrm{tr}(SS^\dagger T_I) = \mathrm{tr}(T_I).$$

1.6 Position and Momentum Representations

1) Continuous spectrum

Unlike the spin angular momentum $\hat{s}_z$, which takes discrete values, position $\hat{x}$ and momentum $\hat{p}$ take continuous values.

The eigenstates of position or momentum constitute a continuous position or momentum representation.

Eigenvalue equations:

$$\hat{x}\,|x\rangle = x\,|x\rangle\,, \qquad \hat{p}\,|p\rangle = p\,|p\rangle\,.$$

Basis vectors: $|x\rangle$, $|p\rangle$.

Orthonormality:

$$\langle x|x'\rangle = \delta(x - x'), \qquad \langle p|p'\rangle = \delta(p - p').$$

Completeness:

$$\int \mathrm{d}x\ |x\rangle \langle x| = \mathbf{1}, \qquad \int \mathrm{d}p\ |p\rangle \langle p| = \mathbf{1}.$$

For an arbitrary state $|\psi\rangle$,

$$|\psi\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}x\ |x\rangle\,\langle x|\psi\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}p\ |p\rangle\,\langle p|\psi\rangle\,.$$

The functions $\langle x|\psi\rangle$ and $\langle p|\psi\rangle$ are the concrete forms of $|\psi\rangle$ in the position and momentum representations; they are continuous column matrices.

In three-dimensional space,

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}\,|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle = \boldsymbol{x}\,|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,, \qquad \hat{\boldsymbol{p}}\,|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle = \boldsymbol{p}\,|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle\,.$$

Postulate of quantum mechanics: The fundamental commutation relations are

$$[\hat{x}_i, \hat{x}_j] = 0, \qquad [\hat{p}_i, \hat{p}_j] = 0, \qquad [\hat{x}_i, \hat{p}_j] = \mathrm{i}\hbar\delta_{ij}, \quad i,j = 1,2,3.$$

The position–momentum uncertainty relation is

$$\langle(\Delta\hat{x})^2\rangle\langle(\Delta\hat{p}_x)^2\rangle \geq \left(\frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}}\langle[\hat{x},\hat{p}_x]\rangle\right)^2 = \frac{\hbar^2}{4}.$$

2) Spatial translations

Define the spatial-translation operator by

$$\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\,|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle = |\boldsymbol{x} + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,.$$

For an arbitrary state $|\psi\rangle$,

$$\begin{aligned}
\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\,|\psi\rangle &= \hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}) \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ |\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ |\boldsymbol{x} + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle \qquad \text{(the operator acts only on vectors)} \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ |\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x} - \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle \qquad \text{(change of integration variable).}
\end{aligned}$$

For an infinitesimal translation, take

$$\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}) = \mathbf{1} - \mathrm{i}\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x},$$

where the generator $\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}$ is Hermitian.

A translation is a unitary operator:

$$\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\hat{T}^\dagger(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}) = (\mathbf{1} - \mathrm{i}\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})(\mathbf{1} + \mathrm{i}\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}) = \mathbf{1},$$

neglecting second-order infinitesimals.

Composition law for translations:

$$\begin{aligned}
\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_1)\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_2) &= (\mathbf{1} - \mathrm{i}\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_1)(\mathbf{1} - \mathrm{i}\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_2) \\
&= \mathbf{1} - \mathrm{i}\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}\cdot(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_1 + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_2) = \hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_1 + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}_2).
\end{aligned}$$

A finite translation is obtained by repeated infinitesimal translations.

For an arbitrary state $|\psi\rangle$,

$$\begin{aligned}
\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\,|\psi\rangle &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\,\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}\,|\boldsymbol{x} + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\,(\boldsymbol{x} + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\,|\boldsymbol{x} + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle\,, \\
\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}\,|\psi\rangle &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\,\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\boldsymbol{x}\,|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\,\boldsymbol{x}\,|\boldsymbol{x} + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle\,.
\end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$[\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})]\,|\psi\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}^3x\,\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\;|\boldsymbol{x}+\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle$$
$$= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\,\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\;|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi\rangle = \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\,|\psi\rangle\,,$$

where second-order infinitesimals have been neglected. Thus

$$[\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})] = \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}, \qquad [\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{\boldsymbol{K}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}] = \mathrm{i}\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}.$$

If the translation is taken in the x_j direction, $\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x} = \epsilon\boldsymbol{e}_j$, then

$$[\hat{x}_i, \hat{K}_j] = \mathrm{i}\delta_{ij}.$$

Comparing with the fundamental quantum-mechanical commutation relation,

$$[\hat{x}_i, \hat{p}_j] = \mathrm{i}\hbar\delta_{ij},$$

we have

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} = \hbar\hat{\boldsymbol{K}}.$$

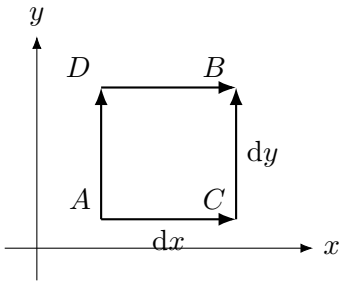
Momentum is therefore the generator of translations, and

$$\boxed{\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}) = \mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}.}$$

Since $[\hat{p}_x, \hat{p}_y] = 0$,

$$[\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}x), \hat{T}(\mathrm{d}y)] = \left[\mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{p}_x\mathrm{d}x, \mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{p}_y\mathrm{d}y\right] = 0.$$

This shows that the order of translations is immaterial. Translating $A \to C$ by $\mathrm{d}x$ and then $C \to B$ by $\mathrm{d}y$ gives the same result as translating $A \to D$ by $\mathrm{d}y$ and then $D \to B$ by $\mathrm{d}x$.



3) Canonical quantization

Dirac, 1925: quantization of classical mechanical systems.

The Poisson bracket of analytical mechanics is replaced by a commutation relation in quantum mechanics:

$$[A, B]_{\mathrm{P}} = \sum_s \left(\frac{\partial A}{\partial q_s}\frac{\partial B}{\partial p_s} - \frac{\partial A}{\partial p_s}\frac{\partial B}{\partial q_s}\right) \longrightarrow \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{A}, \hat{B}] = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}(\hat{A}\hat{B} - \hat{B}\hat{A}).$$

For example,

$$[x_i, p_j]_{\mathrm{P}} = \delta_{ij} \longrightarrow [\hat{x}_i, \hat{p}_j] = \mathrm{i}\hbar\delta_{ij}.$$

4) Position representation

The matrix elements of $\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}$ are

$$\langle \boldsymbol{x}_1|\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}|\boldsymbol{x}_2\rangle = \boldsymbol{x}_2\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}_1-\boldsymbol{x}_2) = \boldsymbol{x}_1\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}_1-\boldsymbol{x}_2),$$

so the position operator is diagonal.

From

$$\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\,|\beta\rangle = \left(\mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\right)|\beta\rangle$$

and

$$\begin{aligned}\hat{T}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\,|\beta\rangle &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ |\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}-\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}|\beta\rangle \\ &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ |\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,(\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\beta\rangle - \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\cdot\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}}\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\beta\rangle) \\ &= |\beta\rangle - \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\cdot\int \mathrm{d}^3x\ |\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}}\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\beta\rangle\,,\end{aligned}$$

we obtain

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}\,|\beta\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ |\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}})\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\beta\rangle\,,$$

and

$$\langle\alpha|\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}|\beta\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ \langle\alpha|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}})\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\beta\rangle\,.$$

Taking $|\alpha\rangle = |\boldsymbol{x}_1\rangle$ and $|\beta\rangle = |\boldsymbol{x}_2\rangle$ gives the matrix elements of momentum in the position representation:

$$\langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}|\boldsymbol{x}_2\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ \langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}})\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\boldsymbol{x}_2\rangle = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}_1}\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}_1-\boldsymbol{x}_2).$$

Now take $|\alpha\rangle = |\boldsymbol{x}_1\rangle$ and $|\beta\rangle = |\boldsymbol{p}\rangle$:

$$\langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}^3x\ \langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle\,(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}})\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}_1}\langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle\,.$$

But the momentum eigenvalue equation gives

$$\boldsymbol{p}\,\langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{x}_1}\langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle\,.$$

Solving this first-order differential equation, we find that the momentum eigenstate in the position representation is a plane wave:

$$\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle = N\exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\boldsymbol{p}\cdot\boldsymbol{x}\right).$$

Using

$$\begin{aligned}\langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\boldsymbol{x}_2\rangle &= \int \mathrm{d}^3p\ \langle\boldsymbol{x}_1|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{p}|\boldsymbol{x}_2\rangle \\ &= |N|^2\int \mathrm{d}^3p\,\exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\boldsymbol{p}\cdot(\boldsymbol{x}_1-\boldsymbol{x}_2)\right],\end{aligned}$$

and

$$\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}_1-\boldsymbol{x}_2) = |N|^2(2\pi\hbar)^3\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}_1-\boldsymbol{x}_2),$$

we obtain

$$N = \frac{1}{(2\pi\hbar)^{3/2}}, \qquad \boxed{\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle = \frac{1}{(2\pi\hbar)^{3/2}}\exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\boldsymbol{p}\cdot\boldsymbol{x}\right).}$$

5) Momentum representation

The matrix elements of the momentum operator are

$$\langle \boldsymbol{p}_1|\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}|\boldsymbol{p}_2\rangle = \boldsymbol{p}_1\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{p}_1-\boldsymbol{p}_2),$$

so the momentum operator is diagonal.

For the position operator,

$$\begin{aligned}
\langle \boldsymbol{p}_1|\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}|\boldsymbol{p}_2\rangle &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x_1\mathrm{d}^3x_2\ \langle \boldsymbol{p}_1|\boldsymbol{x}_1\rangle\langle \boldsymbol{x}_1|\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}|\boldsymbol{x}_2\rangle\langle \boldsymbol{x}_2|\boldsymbol{p}_2\rangle \\
&= \frac{1}{(2\pi\hbar)^3}\int \mathrm{d}^3x_1\mathrm{d}^3x_2\ \exp\left(-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\boldsymbol{p}_1\cdot\boldsymbol{x}_1\right)\boldsymbol{x}_2\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}_1-\boldsymbol{x}_2)\exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\boldsymbol{p}_2\cdot\boldsymbol{x}_2\right) \\
&= \frac{1}{(2\pi\hbar)^3}\int \mathrm{d}^3x_1\,\boldsymbol{x}_1\exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}(\boldsymbol{p}_2-\boldsymbol{p}_1)\cdot\boldsymbol{x}_1\right] \\
&= \mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{p}_1}\frac{1}{(2\pi\hbar)^3}\int \mathrm{d}^3x_1\ \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}(\boldsymbol{p}_2-\boldsymbol{p}_1)\cdot\boldsymbol{x}_1\right] \\
&= \mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla}_{\boldsymbol{p}_1}\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{p}_1-\boldsymbol{p}_2).
\end{aligned}$$

Note that differentiation here is with respect to momentum.

The form of the position eigenstate in the momentum representation is

$$\boxed{\langle \boldsymbol{p}|\boldsymbol{x}\rangle = \langle \boldsymbol{x}|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle^* = \frac{1}{(2\pi\hbar)^{3/2}}\exp\left(-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\boldsymbol{p}\cdot\boldsymbol{x}\right).}$$

Example 1: Prove that $\hat{x}$ and $\hat{p}$ are Hermitian operators in the position representation. For position,

$$\langle x_1|\hat{x}|x_2\rangle = \delta(x_1-x_2)x_1,$$

and

$$\begin{aligned}
\left\langle x_1\middle|\hat{x}^\dagger\middle|x_2\right\rangle &= \langle x_2|\hat{x}|x_1\rangle^* = [\delta(x_2-x_1)x_2]^* = \delta(x_2-x_1)x_2 \\
&= \delta(x_1-x_2)x_1 = \langle x_1|\hat{x}|x_2\rangle\,.
\end{aligned}$$

For momentum,

$$\langle x_1|\hat{p}|x_2\rangle = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}\delta(x_1-x_2) = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial(x_1-x_2)}\delta(x_1-x_2).$$

Also,

$$\begin{aligned}
\left\langle x_1\middle|\hat{p}^\dagger\middle|x_2\right\rangle &= \langle x_2|\hat{p}|x_1\rangle^* = \left[-\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial(x_2-x_1)}\delta(x_2-x_1)\right]^* \\
&= \mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial(x_2-x_1)}\delta(x_2-x_1) = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial(x_1-x_2)}\delta(x_1-x_2) \\
&= \langle x_1|\hat{p}|x_2\rangle\,.
\end{aligned}$$

Thus both $\hat{x}$ and $\hat{p}$ are Hermitian.

Example 2: Compute $[\hat{x},\hat{p}]$ in the position representation.

$$\begin{aligned}
\hat{x}\hat{p} &= \int \mathrm{d}x_1\mathrm{d}x_2\, \hat{x}\, |x_1\rangle\, \langle x_1|\hat{p}|x_2\rangle\, \langle x_2| \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}x_1\mathrm{d}x_2\ |x_1\rangle\ x_1 \left(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}\right) \delta(x_1-x_2)\, \langle x_2| \\
&= -\int \mathrm{d}x_1\mathrm{d}x_2\ |x_1\rangle \left(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}\right) [x_1\, \langle x_1|]\, \delta(x_1-x_2) \quad \text{(integration by parts)} \\
&= -\int \mathrm{d}x_1\ |x_1\rangle \left(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}\right) [x_1\, \langle x_1|] \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}x_1\, x_1\, |x_1\rangle \left(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}\right) \langle x_1| \quad \text{(integration by parts).}
\end{aligned}$$

Similarly,

$$\hat{p}\hat{x} = -\mathrm{i}\hbar + \int \mathrm{d}x_1\, x_1\, |x_1\rangle \left(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}\right) \langle x_1|\,.$$

Therefore

$$[\hat{x},\hat{p}] = \mathrm{i}\hbar.$$

This shows that commutation relations do not depend on the representation.

According to the uncertainty relation, position and momentum cannot simultaneously have definite values. For example, in a momentum eigenstate the momentum has a definite value, $\langle p|(\Delta\hat{p})^2|p\rangle = 0$, but the probability for position to take value x is

$$|\,\langle x|p\rangle\,|^2 = \left|\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi\hbar}} e^{\mathrm{i}px/\hbar}\right|^2 = \text{const.}$$

The particle therefore has equal probability of appearing anywhere in $-\infty < x < \infty$; position is completely indefinite, with variance $\langle p|(\Delta\hat{x})^2|p\rangle = \infty$.

Example 3: Minimum-uncertainty wave packet. For equality to hold in the uncertainty relation

$$\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle\langle(\Delta\hat{B})^2\rangle \geq \left(\frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}}\langle[\hat{A},\hat{B}]\rangle\right)^2,$$

so that the uncertainty is minimal, the state must satisfy:

1) Equality in the Schwarz inequality:

$$\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle\langle(\Delta\hat{B})^2\rangle = |\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle|^2.$$

2) $\mathrm{Re}\langle\Delta\hat{A}\Delta\hat{B}\rangle = 0$.

The solution of condition 1 is

$$\Delta\hat{B}\,|\psi\rangle = c\Delta\hat{A}\,|\psi\rangle\,,$$

where c is a constant. Condition 2 implies

$$\mathrm{Re}\left(c\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle\right) = 0.$$

Since $\langle(\Delta\hat{A})^2\rangle$ is real, $c = \mathrm{i}a$, with a real. Hence

$$(\hat{B} - \langle\hat{B}\rangle)\,|\psi\rangle = \mathrm{i}a(\hat{A} - \langle\hat{A}\rangle)\,|\psi\rangle\,.$$

This is the constraint on $|\psi\rangle$ for minimum uncertainty. Choose

$$\hat{A} = \hat{x}, \qquad \hat{B} = \hat{p},$$

so

$$(\hat{p} - \langle\hat{p}\rangle)\,|\psi\rangle = \mathrm{i}a(\hat{x} - \langle\hat{x}\rangle)\,|\psi\rangle\,.$$

In the position representation,

$$\left(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x} - \langle\hat{p}\rangle\right)\psi(x) = \mathrm{i}a(x - \langle\hat{x}\rangle)\psi(x), \qquad \psi(x) = \langle x|\psi\rangle\,.$$

The solution is

$$\psi(x) = A\exp\left[-\frac{a(x-\langle\hat{x}\rangle)^2}{2\hbar}\right]\exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\langle\hat{p}\rangle x\right),$$

a Gaussian wave packet in position space.

Example 4: The ground state of the hydrogen atom. Given the state in the position representation

$$\langle\boldsymbol{r}|\psi\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi a_0^3}}e^{-r/a_0} \qquad \text{(hydrogen-atom ground state)},$$

find the expectation value of the momentum.

Since $\langle\boldsymbol{r}|\psi\rangle$ is not a plane wave, momentum has no definite value. The probability for momentum $\boldsymbol{p}$ is $|\,\langle\boldsymbol{p}|\psi\rangle\,|^2$, where

$$\begin{aligned}\langle\boldsymbol{p}|\psi\rangle &= \int \mathrm{d}^3r\ \langle\boldsymbol{p}|\boldsymbol{r}\rangle\,\langle\boldsymbol{r}|\psi\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}^3r\ \langle\boldsymbol{r}|\boldsymbol{p}\rangle^*\,\langle\boldsymbol{r}|\psi\rangle \\ &= \int \mathrm{d}^3r\,\frac{1}{(2\pi\hbar)^{3/2}}\exp\left(-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\boldsymbol{p}\cdot\boldsymbol{r}\right)\frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi a_0^3}}e^{-r/a_0} \\ &= \frac{(2a_0\hbar)^{3/2}\hbar}{\pi(a_0^2p^2+\hbar^2)^2}.\end{aligned}$$

Since $\langle\boldsymbol{p}|\psi\rangle$ depends only on the magnitude of momentum, the expectation value of the momentum magnitude is

$$\langle p\rangle = \frac{\displaystyle\int \mathrm{d}p\,p^3|\,\langle\boldsymbol{p}|\psi\rangle\,|^2}{\displaystyle\int \mathrm{d}p\,p^2|\,\langle\boldsymbol{p}|\psi\rangle\,|^2}.$$

Chapter 2

Quantum Dynamics

2.1 Time Evolution and the Schrödinger Equation

This chapter discusses the time evolution of states and physical quantities in quantum mechanics. Unlike other physical quantities, which are represented by operators, time in nonrelativistic quantum mechanics is only a parameter; it remains a classical quantity and is not an operator.

1) Time-evolution (translation) operator

Initial state: $|\alpha, t_0\rangle$.

Evolution from t_0 to t:

$$|\alpha, t\rangle = \hat{U}(t, t_0)\,|\alpha, t_0\rangle\,.$$

Expand $|\alpha, t_0\rangle$ and $|\alpha, t\rangle$ in eigenstates $|a\rangle$ of an operator $\hat{A}$:

$$|\alpha, t_0\rangle = \sum_a |a\rangle\,\langle a|\alpha, t_0\rangle\,, \qquad |\alpha, t\rangle = \sum_a |a\rangle\,\langle a|\alpha, t\rangle\,.$$

Clearly, the probability of occupying a particular eigenstate is not necessarily conserved:

$$|\,\langle a|\alpha, t_0\rangle\,|^2 \neq |\,\langle a|\alpha, t\rangle\,|^2.$$

However, the normalization condition

$$\langle \alpha, t|\alpha, t\rangle = \langle \alpha, t_0|\alpha, t_0\rangle = 1$$

implies conservation of the total probability,

$$\sum_a |\,\langle a|\alpha, t\rangle\,|^2 = \sum_a |\,\langle a|\alpha, t_0\rangle\,|^2 = 1,$$

and the time-evolution operator is unitary:

$$\hat{U}^\dagger(t, t_0)\hat{U}(t, t_0) = \mathbf{1}.$$

Require the composition law for time evolution:

$$\hat{U}(t_2, t_0) = \hat{U}(t_2, t_1)\hat{U}(t_1, t_0), \qquad t_2 > t_1 > t_0.$$

An infinitesimal time-evolution operator can be written

$$\hat{U}(t_0 + \mathrm{d}t, t_0) = \mathbf{1} - \mathrm{i}\hat{\Omega}\,\mathrm{d}t.$$

Unitarity, $\hat{U}^\dagger\hat{U} = \mathbf{1}$, requires $\hat{\Omega}$ to be Hermitian:

$$\hat{\Omega}^\dagger = \hat{\Omega}.$$

Since $\hat{U}$ is dimensionless, $\hat{\Omega}$ has dimensions of frequency. By the Planck–Einstein energy–frequency relation $E = \hbar\omega$, we may set

$$\hat{\Omega} = \frac{\hat{H}}{\hbar}, \qquad \boxed{\hat{U}(t_0 + \mathrm{d}t, t_0) = \mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{H}\,\mathrm{d}t.}$$

2) Equation of time evolution

Using the composition law,

$$\hat{U}(t+\mathrm{d}t,t_0)=\hat{U}(t+\mathrm{d}t,t)\hat{U}(t,t_0)=\left(\mathbf{1}-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{H}\mathrm{d}t\right)\hat{U}(t,t_0).$$

Hence

$$\frac{\hat{U}(t+\mathrm{d}t,t_0)-\hat{U}(t,t_0)}{\mathrm{d}t}=-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{H}\hat{U}(t,t_0),$$

so that

$$\boxed{\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}\hat{U}(t,t_0)=\hat{H}\hat{U}(t,t_0).}$$

This is the fundamental equation of time evolution in quantum mechanics.

Multiplying the equation on the right by the initial state $|\alpha,t_0\rangle$ gives

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}\hat{U}(t,t_0)\,|\alpha,t_0\rangle=\hat{H}\hat{U}(t,t_0)\,|\alpha,t_0\rangle\,,$$

$$\boxed{\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}\,|\alpha,t\rangle=\hat{H}\,|\alpha,t\rangle\,.}$$

This is the equation governing the time evolution of a state, the Schrödinger equation.

We now discuss solutions of this fundamental equation. If the Hamiltonian has no explicit time dependence, for example the magnetic interaction $\hat{H}\sim\hat{J}_zB$ in a constant magnetic field directed along z,

$$\boxed{\hat{U}(t,t_0)=\exp\left[-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{H}(t-t_0)\right].}$$

If the Hamiltonian depends on time but the Hamiltonians at different times commute, for example $\hat{H}(t)\sim\hat{J}_zB(t)$ when the magnitude but not the direction of the magnetic field changes,

$$\hat{U}(t,t_0)=\exp\left[-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\int_{t_0}^{t}\hat{H}(t')\mathrm{d}t'\right].$$

If the Hamiltonian depends on time and the Hamiltonians at different times do not commute, for example $\hat{H}(t)\sim\boldsymbol{J}\cdot\boldsymbol{B}(t)$ when both the magnitude and direction of the field vary,

$$\hat{U}(t,t_0)=\mathbf{1}+\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}\left(-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\right)^n\int_{t_0}^{t}\mathrm{d}t_1\int_{t_0}^{t_1}\mathrm{d}t_2\cdots\int_{t_0}^{t_{n-1}}\mathrm{d}t_n \times\hat{H}(t_1)\hat{H}(t_2)\cdots\hat{H}(t_n).$$

This is called the Dyson series.

Below we mainly consider Hamiltonians that do not depend explicitly on time.

3) Stationary states

Suppose initially the system is in an eigenstate of $\hat{H}$:

$$|\alpha,t_0\rangle=|E\rangle\,,\qquad\hat{H}\,|E\rangle=E\,|E\rangle\,.$$

Then

$$|\alpha,t\rangle=e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar}\,|\alpha,t_0\rangle=e^{-\mathrm{i}E(t-t_0)/\hbar}\,|\alpha,t_0\rangle\,.$$

The state changes only by a phase. The expectation value of any physical quantity $\hat{A}$ is

$$\left\langle\alpha,t\middle|\hat{A}\middle|\alpha,t\right\rangle=\left\langle\alpha,t_0\middle|e^{\mathrm{i}E(t-t_0)/\hbar}\hat{A}e^{-\mathrm{i}E(t-t_0)/\hbar}\middle|\alpha,t_0\right\rangle=\left\langle\alpha,t_0\middle|\hat{A}\middle|\alpha,t_0\right\rangle$$

and does not change with time. Therefore, energy eigenstates are called stationary states.

If the system is initially not in a stationary state, its amplitude for occupying the stationary state $|E\rangle$ at time t is

$$\langle E|\alpha,t\rangle = \langle E|\, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar}\,|\alpha,t_0\rangle = e^{-\mathrm{i}E(t-t_0)/\hbar}\,\langle E|\alpha,t_0\rangle\,,$$

and its probability satisfies

$$|\,\langle E|\alpha,t\rangle\,|^2 = |\,\langle E|\alpha,t_0\rangle\,|^2.$$

The probability of occupying any stationary state is the same at all times as it was initially. Thus, if the system initially occupies a stationary state, it remains in that state; if its initial state is not stationary, it remains nonstationary.

4) Electron-spin precession

Consider the interaction of an electron's spin magnetic moment with an external magnetic field directed along z:

$$\hat{H} = -\left(\frac{e}{mc}\right)\hat{\boldsymbol{s}}\cdot\boldsymbol{B} = -\frac{eB}{mc}\hat{s}_z = \omega\hat{s}_z, \qquad \omega = -\frac{eB}{mc} > 0.$$

The time-evolution operator is

$$\hat{U}(t,0) = e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}t/\hbar} = e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega\hat{s}_z t/\hbar}.$$

The operators $\hat{s}_z$ and $\hat{H}$ have common eigenstates $|s_z^{\pm}\rangle$:

$$\hat{s}_z\,|s_z^{\pm}\rangle = \pm\frac{\hbar}{2}\,|s_z^{\pm}\rangle\,, \qquad \hat{H}\,|s_z^{\pm}\rangle = \pm\frac{\hbar\omega}{2}\,|s_z^{\pm}\rangle\,.$$

Suppose the system initially occupies the positive eigenstate of $\hat{s}_x$:

$$|\alpha,0\rangle = \left|s_x^{+}\right\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\left|s_z^{+}\right\rangle + \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\,|s_z^{-}\rangle\,.$$

At an arbitrary time,

$$|\alpha,t\rangle = \hat{U}(t,0)\,|\alpha,0\rangle\,.$$

The probability of finding the system in $|s_x^{+}\rangle$ is

$$\begin{aligned}|\left\langle s_x^{+}\right|\alpha,t\rangle\,|^2 &= \left|\left(\frac{\langle s_z^{+}| + \langle s_z^{-}|}{\sqrt{2}}\right)e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega\hat{s}_z t/\hbar}\left(\frac{|s_z^{+}\rangle + |s_z^{-}\rangle}{\sqrt{2}}\right)\right|^2 \\ &= \left|\frac{e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega t/2} + e^{\mathrm{i}\omega t/2}}{2}\right|^2 = \cos^2\frac{\omega t}{2}.\end{aligned}$$

By conservation of probability,

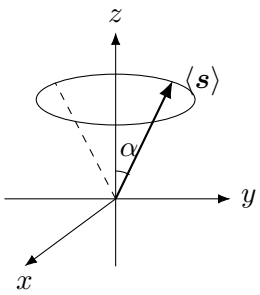
$$|\,\langle s_x^{-}|\alpha,t\rangle\,|^2 = 1 - |\left\langle s_x^{+}\right|\alpha,t\rangle\,|^2 = \sin^2\frac{\omega t}{2}.$$

The expectation value at an arbitrary time is

$$\begin{aligned}\langle s_x\rangle &= \langle\alpha,t|\hat{s}_x|\alpha,t\rangle = \sum_{s_x} s_x|\,\langle s_x|\alpha,t\rangle\,|^2 \\ &= \frac{\hbar}{2}\left(\cos^2\frac{\omega t}{2} - \sin^2\frac{\omega t}{2}\right) = \frac{\hbar}{2}\cos\omega t.\end{aligned}$$

Similarly,

$$\langle s_y\rangle = \frac{\hbar}{2}\sin\omega t, \qquad \langle s_z\rangle = 0.$$



The expectation value $\langle \boldsymbol{s} \rangle$ precesses about the z axis with time; the trajectory is a cone. This is the spin Larmor precession, with ω the Larmor frequency.

5) Energy–time uncertainty relation

From

$$\langle (\Delta \hat{x})^2 \rangle \langle (\Delta \hat{p})^2 \rangle \geq \frac{\hbar^2}{4},$$

we obtain $\Delta x \, \Delta p \geq \hbar/2$, where

$$\Delta A = \sqrt{\langle (\Delta \hat{A})^2 \rangle}.$$

By classical analogy, $x = x(t)$ and $p = p(E, p)$, one may suppose

$$\Delta t \, \Delta E \geq \frac{\hbar}{2}.$$

This is the energy–time uncertainty relation. However, unlike x, p, E, $\hat{x}$, $\hat{p}$, and $\hat{H}$ in quantum mechanics, time t remains a classical quantity. What does Δt mean?

What are $\langle (\Delta \hat{H})^2 \rangle$ and $\langle (\Delta t)^2 \rangle$?

For an arbitrary observable $\hat{O}$,

$$\langle O \rangle (t) = \left\langle \alpha, t \middle| \hat{O} \middle| \alpha, t \right\rangle .$$

Its time derivative is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t} \langle O \rangle = \left(\frac{\partial}{\partial t} \langle \alpha, t | \right) \hat{O} \, | \alpha, t \rangle + \langle \alpha, t | \, \frac{\partial \hat{O}}{\partial t} \, | \alpha, t \rangle + \langle \alpha, t | \, \hat{O} \left(\frac{\partial}{\partial t} \, | \alpha, t \rangle \right).$$

Since

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar \frac{\partial}{\partial t} \, | \alpha, t \rangle = \hat{H} \, | \alpha, t \rangle , \qquad -\mathrm{i}\hbar \frac{\partial}{\partial t} \, \langle \alpha, t | = \langle \alpha, t | \, \hat{H},$$

we have

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t} \langle O \rangle = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar} \left\langle \alpha, t \middle| [\hat{O}, \hat{H}] \middle| \alpha, t \right\rangle + \left\langle \frac{\partial \hat{O}}{\partial t} \right\rangle .$$

If $\hat{O}$ has no explicit time dependence,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t} \langle O \rangle = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar} \langle [\hat{O}, \hat{H}] \rangle .$$

Consequently, the uncertainty relation between $\hat{O}$ and $\hat{H}$ gives

$$\langle (\Delta \hat{O})^2 \rangle \langle (\Delta \hat{H})^2 \rangle \geq \left| \frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}} \langle [\hat{O}, \hat{H}] \rangle \right|^2 = \frac{\hbar^2}{4} \left(\frac{\mathrm{d} \langle O \rangle}{\mathrm{d}t} \right)^2 .$$

Therefore

$$\Delta O \, \Delta E \geq \frac{\hbar}{2} \left| \frac{\mathrm{d} \langle O \rangle}{\mathrm{d}t} \right| .$$

If we define

$$\Delta t = \Delta O \left| \frac{\mathrm{d}\langle O \rangle}{\mathrm{d}t} \right|^{-1},$$

then

$$\boxed{\Delta t \, \Delta E \geq \frac{\hbar}{2}.}$$

Thus Δt is the time needed for the expectation value of a physical quantity $\hat{O}$ to change by an amount equal to one standard deviation ΔO. Clearly, both Δt and ΔE are averages and uncertainties of physical quantities.

Example. In a stationary state $\Delta E = 0$, and $\langle \hat{O} \rangle$ is time independent:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\langle O \rangle = 0, \qquad \Delta t = \Delta O \left| \frac{\mathrm{d}\langle O \rangle}{\mathrm{d}t} \right|^{-1} \longrightarrow \infty.$$

2.2 Schrödinger and Heisenberg Pictures

1) Two kinds of unitary transformations

The spatial-translation operator $\hat{U}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})$ and time-translation operator $\hat{U}(\mathrm{d}t)$ discussed earlier both act on the state:

$$|\alpha\rangle \longrightarrow \hat{U}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\,|\alpha\rangle = \left(\mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\right)|\alpha\rangle\,,$$

$$|\alpha\rangle \longrightarrow \hat{U}(\mathrm{d}t)\,|\alpha\rangle = \left(\mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{H}\,\mathrm{d}t\right)|\alpha\rangle\,.$$

The physical quantities remain unchanged; observable differences arise from changes in the state. Under a unitary change of the state,

$$\left\langle \beta \middle| \hat{A} \middle| \alpha \right\rangle \longrightarrow \langle \beta |\, \hat{U}^\dagger \hat{A} \hat{U}\, |\alpha\rangle\,.$$

Equivalently, one may leave the state $|\alpha\rangle$ unchanged and transform the physical quantity:

$$\boxed{\hat{A} \longrightarrow \hat{U}^\dagger \hat{A} \hat{U}, \qquad |\alpha\rangle \text{ unchanged.}}$$

The two methods are completely equivalent: the time dependence may be assigned either to the state or to the observable. For example, under a spatial displacement,

$$\hat{x} \longrightarrow \hat{U}^\dagger(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x})\hat{x}\hat{U}(\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}) = \left(\mathbf{1} + \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\right)\hat{x}\left(\mathbf{1} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}\right) = \hat{x} + \frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}[\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}, \hat{x}] = \hat{x} + \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}.$$

2) Schrödinger and Heisenberg pictures of time evolution

In the *Schrödinger picture*, the state evolves as

$$|\alpha, t\rangle_{\mathrm{S}} = \hat{U}(t)\,|\alpha, 0\rangle_{\mathrm{S}}\,, \qquad \hat{U}(t) = e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}t/\hbar},$$

while the observable $\hat{A}_{\mathrm{S}}$ remains fixed in time.

In the *Heisenberg picture*, the observable evolves as

$$\hat{A}_{\mathrm{H}}(t) = \hat{U}^\dagger(t)\hat{A}_{\mathrm{H}}(0)\hat{U}(t),$$

while the state $|\alpha\rangle_{\mathrm{H}}$ remains fixed.

For the same initial conditions,

$$\hat{A}_{\mathrm{H}}(0) = \hat{A}_{\mathrm{S}}, \qquad |\alpha, 0\rangle_{\mathrm{S}} = |\alpha\rangle_{\mathrm{H}}\,.$$

These are the relations between the two pictures.

Notes.

1. Inner products (including matrix elements, probability amplitudes and expectation values) are independent of picture:

$$_{\rm S}\langle\alpha,t|\beta,t\rangle_{\rm S} = {}_{\rm S}\langle\alpha,0|\,\hat{U}^\dagger\hat{U}\,|\beta,0\rangle_{\rm S} = {}_{\rm S}\langle\alpha,0|\beta,0\rangle_{\rm S} = {}_{\rm H}\langle\alpha|\beta\rangle_{\rm H}\,.$$

2. Since a unitary transformation preserves commutators, if the Schrödinger-picture commutation relation is

$$[\hat{A}_{\rm S},\hat{B}_{\rm S}] = \hat{C}_{\rm S},$$

or equivalently initially $[\hat{A}_{\rm H}(0),\hat{B}_{\rm H}(0)] = \hat{C}_{\rm H}(0)$, then the equal-time relation is

$$[\hat{A}_{\rm H}(t),\hat{B}_{\rm H}(t)] = \hat{C}_{\rm H}(t).$$

3. The Hamiltonian in the previously introduced time-evolution operator $\hat{U}(t) = e^{-{\rm i}\hat{H}t/\hbar}$ is the Schrödinger-picture Hamiltonian $\hat{H} = \hat{H}_{\rm S}$. For a time-independent Hamiltonian,

$$\hat{H}_{\rm H}(t) = \hat{U}^\dagger(t)\hat{H}_{\rm S}\hat{U}(t) = e^{{\rm i}\hat{H}_{\rm S}t/\hbar}\hat{H}_{\rm S}e^{-{\rm i}\hat{H}_{\rm S}t/\hbar} = \hat{H}_{\rm S} = \hat{H}_{\rm H}.$$

So far we have considered time evolution of states and observables. Do basis vectors also change with time, as general vectors do? Basis vectors are eigenstates of observables; their time dependence is determined by that of the observables.

In the Schrödinger picture,

$$\hat{A}_{\rm S}\,|a\rangle_{\rm S} = a\,|a\rangle_{\rm S}\,.$$

Since $\hat{A}_{\rm S}$ is time independent, its eigenbasis $|a\rangle_{\rm S}$ is also time independent.

In the Heisenberg picture,

$$\hat{A}_{\rm H}(t)\,|a,t\rangle_{\rm H} = a\,|a,t\rangle_{\rm H}\,.$$

Since $\hat{A}_{\rm H}$ depends on time, its basis $|a,t\rangle_{\rm H}$ also depends on time. Using

$$\hat{U}^\dagger(t)\hat{A}_{\rm S}\hat{U}(t)\,|a,t\rangle_{\rm H} = a\,|a,t\rangle_{\rm H}\,,$$

we obtain

$$\hat{A}_{\rm S}\hat{U}(t)\,|a,t\rangle_{\rm H} = a\hat{U}(t)\,|a,t\rangle_{\rm H}\,.$$

Comparison with the Schrödinger-picture eigenvalue equation gives

$$\hat{U}(t)\,|a,t\rangle_{\rm H} = |a\rangle_{\rm S}\,,\quad |a,t\rangle_{\rm H} = \hat{U}^\dagger(t)\,|a\rangle_{\rm S} = \hat{U}^\dagger(t)\,|a,0\rangle_{\rm H}\,.$$

In summary:

	Schrödinger picture	Heisenberg picture
State	$\|\alpha,t\rangle_{\rm S} = \hat{U}(t)\,\|\alpha,0\rangle_{\rm S}$	$\|\alpha\rangle_{\rm H}$ fixed
Observable	$\hat{A}_{\rm S}$ fixed	$\hat{A}_{\rm H}(t) = \hat{U}^\dagger\hat{A}_{\rm H}(0)\hat{U}$
Basis	$\|a\rangle_{\rm S}$ fixed	$\|a,t\rangle_{\rm H} = \hat{U}^\dagger(t)\,\|a,0\rangle_{\rm H}$

3) Equation of motion in the Heisenberg picture

In classical mechanics, only physical quantities evolve with time and the notion of a state vector is not introduced. The Heisenberg picture of quantum mechanics is therefore easier to compare with classical mechanics.

Differentiate

$$\hat{A}_{\rm H}(t) = e^{{\rm i}\hat{H}t/\hbar}\hat{A}_{\rm H}(0)e^{-{\rm i}\hat{H}t/\hbar}$$

with respect to time. We obtain the Heisenberg equation of motion:

$$\boxed{\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{A}_{\mathrm{H}}(t)}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{A}_{\mathrm{H}}(t), \hat{H}].}$$

It plays a role similar to the Schrödinger-picture equation for the state,

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}\left|\alpha, t\right\rangle_{\mathrm{S}} = \hat{H}\left|\alpha, t\right\rangle_{\mathrm{S}}.$$

Compare the equation of motion of analytical classical mechanics,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}t} = \{A, H\}_{\mathrm{Poisson}}.$$

We obtain the route from classical mechanics to quantum mechanics, canonical quantization:

$$\boxed{\{\ ,\ \}_{\mathrm{Poisson}} \quad \xrightarrow{\text{quantum mechanics}} \quad \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\ ,\ ].}$$

4) Ehrenfest theorem

How is $\hat{H}$ constructed? For a quantum system with a classical counterpart, the Hamiltonian $H(\boldsymbol{x}, \boldsymbol{p})$ of analytical mechanics is taken to the quantum Hamiltonian $\hat{H}(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{\boldsymbol{p}})$.

For a free particle,

$$\hat{H} = \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}^2}{2m}.$$

Heisenberg equations of motion (we henceforth omit the picture index H on observables) give

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}, \hat{H}] = 0, \qquad \hat{\boldsymbol{p}}(t) = \hat{\boldsymbol{p}}(0),$$

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{H}] = \frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}\hbar m}[\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{\boldsymbol{p}}^2] = \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}(t)}{m} = \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}(0)}{m}, \quad \hat{\boldsymbol{x}}(t) = \hat{\boldsymbol{x}}(0) + \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}(0)}{m}t.$$

For a general system,

$$\hat{H} = \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}^2}{2m} + V(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}).$$

The Heisenberg equations are

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}, \hat{H}] = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}, V(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}})].$$

Expand $V(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}})$ as a power series in $\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}$ and use $[\hat{x}_i, \hat{p}_j] = \mathrm{i}\hbar\delta_{ij}$. Then

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}}{\mathrm{d}t} = -\boldsymbol{\nabla}V(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}),$$

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{H}] = \frac{1}{2\mathrm{i}\hbar m}[\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, \hat{\boldsymbol{p}}^2] = \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}}{m},$$

$$m\frac{\mathrm{d}^2\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = \frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}}{\mathrm{d}t} = -\boldsymbol{\nabla}V(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}).$$

Taking expectation values on both sides,

$$\boxed{m\frac{\mathrm{d}^2\langle\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}\rangle}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = \frac{\mathrm{d}\langle\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}\rangle}{\mathrm{d}t} = -\langle\boldsymbol{\nabla}V(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}})\rangle.}$$

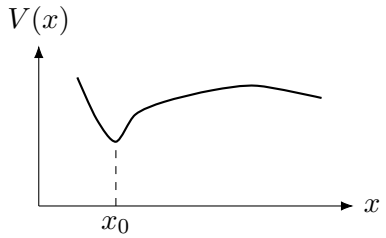
This is the Ehrenfest theorem, corresponding to Newton's law in classical mechanics. Since inner products are picture-independent, the Ehrenfest theorem for expectation values is also picture-independent.

Unless otherwise stated, problems below are generally discussed in the Schrödinger picture.

2.3 One-Dimensional Linear Harmonic Oscillator

For an arbitrary potential, expand it in a Taylor series near a minimum x_0:

$$V(x) = V(x_0) + V'(x_0)(x - x_0) + \frac{1}{2}V''(x_0)(x - x_0)^2 + \cdots .$$



The constant term $V(x_0)$ can be incorporated into the energy. At the potential minimum $V'(x_0) = 0$. Omitting higher-order terms,

$$V(x) \simeq \frac{1}{2}V''(x_0)(x - x_0)^2.$$

This approximates a harmonic-oscillator potential; therefore the harmonic oscillator has general significance.

Classically,

$$H = \frac{p^2}{2m} + \frac{1}{2}m\omega^2 x^2.$$

Quantum mechanically,

$$\hat{H} = \frac{\hat{p}^2}{2m} + \frac{1}{2}m\omega^2\hat{x}^2, \qquad [\hat{x}, \hat{p}] = \mathrm{i}\hbar.$$

Because

$$\hat{H} = \frac{m\omega^2}{2}\left(\hat{x} - \frac{\mathrm{i}\hat{p}}{m\omega}\right)\left(\hat{x} + \frac{\mathrm{i}\hat{p}}{m\omega}\right) + \frac{1}{2}\hbar\omega,$$

define new operators

$$\hat{a} = \sqrt{\frac{m\omega}{2\hbar}}\left(\hat{x} + \frac{\mathrm{i}\hat{p}}{m\omega}\right), \qquad \hat{a}^\dagger = \sqrt{\frac{m\omega}{2\hbar}}\left(\hat{x} - \frac{\mathrm{i}\hat{p}}{m\omega}\right).$$

Then

$$\boxed{\hat{H} = \left(\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a} + \frac{1}{2}\right)\hbar\omega, \qquad [\hat{a}, \hat{a}^\dagger] = \mathbf{1}.}$$

Clearly, $\hat{a}$ is not Hermitian, $\hat{a}^\dagger \neq \hat{a}$. However, $\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}$ is Hermitian:

$$(\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a})^\dagger = \hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}.$$

Since $\hat{H}$ differs from $\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}$ only by a constant, they have common eigenstates. Let

$$\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}\,|n\rangle = n\,|n\rangle\,.$$

Then

$$\hat{H}\,|n\rangle = \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right)\hbar\omega\,|n\rangle\,, \qquad E_n = \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right)\hbar\omega.$$

Questions: What are the eigenvalues n? What are the coordinate-representation eigenstates $\langle x|n\rangle$?

1) Nonnegativity of the eigenvalues

Let

$$\hat{a}\,|n\rangle = |b\rangle\,.$$

Then

$$\langle n|\,\hat{a}^\dagger = \langle b|\,, \qquad \left\langle n\middle|\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}\middle|n\right\rangle = \langle b|b\rangle\,, \quad n\,\langle n|n\rangle = \langle b|b\rangle\,.$$

Because $\langle b|b\rangle \geq 0$ and $\langle n|n\rangle \geq 0$, we have $n \geq 0$.

2) Raising and lowering operators

From $[\hat{a}, \hat{a}^\dagger] = 1$,

$$\begin{aligned}(\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a})\hat{a}\,|n\rangle &= \hat{a}(\hat{a}\hat{a}^\dagger - 1)\,|n\rangle = \hat{a}(\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a} - 1)\,|n\rangle \\ &= (n-1)\hat{a}\,|n\rangle\,,\end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}(\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a})\hat{a}^\dagger\,|n\rangle &= \hat{a}^\dagger(\hat{a}\hat{a}^\dagger)\,|n\rangle = \hat{a}^\dagger(\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a} + 1)\,|n\rangle \\ &= (n+1)\hat{a}^\dagger\,|n\rangle\,.\end{aligned}$$

If $|n\rangle$ is an eigenstate of $\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}$, so are $\hat{a}\,|n\rangle$ and $\hat{a}^\dagger\,|n\rangle$, with the following relationships:

Eigenstate	Eigenvalue of $\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}$
$(\hat{a}^\dagger)^2\,\lvert n\rangle$	$n+2$
$\hat{a}^\dagger\,\lvert n\rangle$	$n+1$
$\lvert n\rangle$	n
$\hat{a}\,\lvert n\rangle$	$n-1$
$\hat{a}^2\,\lvert n\rangle$	$n-2$

Hence $\hat{a}$ is called the lowering (annihilation) operator and $\hat{a}^\dagger$ the raising (creation) operator. Together with $n \geq 0$, the possible eigenvalues have the form

$$n = n_0, n_0 + 1, n_0 + 2, \ldots, \qquad n_0 \geq 0.$$

3) Lowest eigenvalue

For the lowest eigenvalue n_0, necessarily

$$\hat{a}\,|n_0\rangle = 0.$$

Otherwise $\hat{a}\,|n_0\rangle$ would have eigenvalue $n_0 - 1$, contradicting the assumption that n_0 is the smallest eigenvalue. From

$$\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}\,|n_0\rangle = n_0\,|n_0\rangle = 0$$

we obtain $n_0 = 0$. Therefore

$$\boxed{E_n = \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right)\hbar\omega, \quad n = 0, 1, 2, \ldots.}$$

Notice that so far we have used only the commutation relation, without introducing any specific representation.

4) Matrix elements of creation and annihilation operators

Since $\hat{a}\,|n\rangle$ has eigenvalue $n-1$, and in the absence of degeneracy (one-dimensional bound states are nondegenerate),

$$\hat{a}\,|n\rangle = a_n\,|n-1\rangle\,.$$

Similarly,

$$\hat{a}^\dagger\,|n\rangle = b_n\,|n+1\rangle\,.$$

Because

$$\langle n|\,\hat{a}^\dagger = a_n^*\,\langle n-1|\,, \qquad \langle n|\,\hat{a} = b_n^*\,\langle n+1|\,,$$

we obtain

$$\left\langle n\middle|\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}\middle|n\right\rangle = |a_n|^2\,\langle n-1|n-1\rangle\,, \quad n = |a_n|^2, \quad |a_n| = \sqrt{n},$$

$$\left\langle n\middle|\hat{a}\hat{a}^\dagger\middle|n\right\rangle = |b_n|^2\,\langle n+1|n+1\rangle\,, \quad n+1 = |b_n|^2, \quad |b_n| = \sqrt{n+1}.$$

Choose the phases so that $a_n = \sqrt{n}$ and $b_n = \sqrt{n+1}$. Thus

$$\boxed{\hat{a}\,|n\rangle = \sqrt{n}\,|n-1\rangle\,, \qquad \hat{a}^\dagger\,|n\rangle = \sqrt{n+1}\,|n+1\rangle\,.}$$

5) Representation common to $\hat{H}$ and $\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}$

$$(a^\dagger a)_{mn} = \left\langle m\middle|\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}\middle|n\right\rangle = n\,\langle m|n\rangle = n\delta_{mn},$$

$$H_{mn} = \left\langle m\middle|\hat{H}\middle|n\right\rangle = \left(n+\frac{1}{2}\right)\hbar\omega\delta_{mn}.$$

Both are diagonal matrices, as expected in their own representation. Meanwhile,

$$a_{mn} = \langle m|\hat{a}|n\rangle = \sqrt{n}\,\langle m|n-1\rangle = \sqrt{n}\delta_{m,n-1},$$

$$(a^\dagger)_{mn} = \left\langle m\middle|\hat{a}^\dagger\middle|n\right\rangle = \sqrt{n+1}\,\langle m|n+1\rangle = \sqrt{n+1}\delta_{m,n+1}.$$

Since

$$\hat{x} = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}}(\hat{a}^\dagger + \hat{a}), \qquad \hat{p} = \mathrm{i}\sqrt{\frac{m\hbar\omega}{2}}(\hat{a}^\dagger - \hat{a}),$$

it follows that

$$x_{mn} = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}}(\sqrt{n}\delta_{m,n-1} + \sqrt{n+1}\delta_{m,n+1}),$$

$$p_{mn} = \mathrm{i}\sqrt{\frac{m\hbar\omega}{2}}(-\sqrt{n}\delta_{m,n-1} + \sqrt{n+1}\delta_{m,n+1}).$$

They are nondiagonal matrices. Note that $\langle n|\hat{x}|n\rangle = \langle n|\hat{p}|n\rangle = 0$.

6) Coordinate representation

For the ground state $|0\rangle$,

$$\hat{a}\,|0\rangle = 0, \qquad \left(\hat{x} + \frac{\mathrm{i}}{m\omega}\hat{p}\right)|0\rangle = 0.$$

Multiplying from the left by $\langle x|$ and inserting the completeness relation,

$$\int \mathrm{d}x'\ \langle x|\left(\hat{x} + \frac{\mathrm{i}}{m\omega}\hat{p}\right)|x'\rangle\,\langle x'|0\rangle = 0.$$

Using

$$\langle x|\hat{x}|x'\rangle = x\delta(x-x'), \qquad \langle x|\hat{p}|x'\rangle = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\delta(x-x'), \qquad \langle x'|0\rangle = \psi_0(x'),$$

we obtain

$$\left(x + \frac{\hbar}{m\omega}\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\right)\psi_0(x) = 0.$$

The solution of this first-order differential equation is

$$\psi_0(x) = C\exp\left(-\frac{m\omega x^2}{2\hbar}\right).$$

With the normalization condition

$$\int_{-\infty}^{\infty}|\psi_0(x)|^2\mathrm{d}x = 1,$$

we have

$$\boxed{\psi_0(x) = \left(\frac{m\omega}{\pi\hbar}\right)^{1/4}\exp\left(-\frac{m\omega x^2}{2\hbar}\right).}$$

For an excited state,

$$\begin{aligned}\psi_n(x) = \langle x|n\rangle &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}}\langle x|\,\hat{a}^\dagger\,|n-1\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{n(n-1)}}\langle x|\,(\hat{a}^\dagger)^2\,|n-2\rangle \\ &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{n!}}\langle x|\,(\hat{a}^\dagger)^n\,|0\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{n!}}\left(\frac{m\omega}{2\hbar}\right)^{n/2}\langle x|\left(\hat{x} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{m\omega}\hat{p}\right)^n|0\rangle.\end{aligned}$$

Insert n position completeness relations:

$$\begin{aligned}\psi_n(x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{n!}}\left(\frac{m\omega}{2\hbar}\right)^{n/2}\int \mathrm{d}x_1\cdots\mathrm{d}x_n\ &\left\langle x\middle|\hat{x} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{m\omega}\hat{p}\middle|x_1\right\rangle\left\langle x_1\middle|\hat{x} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{m\omega}\hat{p}\middle|x_2\right\rangle \\ &\cdots\left\langle x_{n-1}\middle|\hat{x} - \frac{\mathrm{i}}{m\omega}\hat{p}\middle|x_n\right\rangle\langle x_n|0\rangle.\end{aligned}$$

Using the position and momentum matrix elements gives

$$\boxed{\psi_n(x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{n!}}\left(\frac{m\omega}{2\hbar}\right)^{n/2}\left(x - \frac{\hbar}{m\omega}\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}x}\right)^n\psi_0(x).}$$

Thus the one-dimensional harmonic-oscillator problem has been solved completely.

7) Physical meaning of $\hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}$

The harmonic-oscillator energies are

$$E_n = \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right)\hbar\omega, \qquad n = 0, 1, 2, 3, \ldots.$$

The ground-state energy $E_0 = \hbar\omega/2 > 0$ is the zero-point energy. An excited state involves quanta of energy $\varepsilon = \hbar\omega$. When the oscillator is in the n-th excited state, n quanta have been excited.

n: quantum number, particle number.

$\hat{N} = \hat{a}^\dagger\hat{a}$ is the particle-number operator; $\hat{a}$ is a particle-annihilation operator and $\hat{a}^\dagger$ a particle-creation operator.

The common representation of $\hat{H}$ and $\hat{N}$ is the particle-number representation.

To summarize the algebraic solution: bound states → discrete spectrum → identify lowering and raising operators for the discrete quantum numbers. The particle-number representation is the foundation of the second-quantization scheme.

8) Casimir effect

Does the zero-point energy have observable effects? Consider the vacuum energy of the quantized electromagnetic field.

According to Planck's studies of blackbody radiation, the electromagnetic field consists of harmonic oscillations of different frequencies ω_k (energy $\hbar\omega_k$). Here k is the wave number, $\omega_k = ck$, and n is the number of photons of energy $\hbar\omega_k$. The total electromagnetic-field energy is written

$$E = 2\int \frac{\mathrm{d}^3k}{(2\pi)^3} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right) \hbar\omega_k.$$

Boundary conditions change the distribution of frequencies, hence the distribution of wave numbers k.

The vacuum is the unexcited state, $n = 0$, with vacuum energy

$$E = \int \frac{\mathrm{d}^3k}{(2\pi)^3} \hbar\omega_k,$$

which is infinite. In ordinary calculations it is subtracted as the background to excitations. The question is whether the vacuum energy itself has observable effects.

Place two parallel plates in the electromagnetic radiation field, each of area L^2 with L sufficiently large and separation $a \ll L$. Boundary conditions restrict the component of wave number perpendicular to the plates to $k_z = n\pi/a$; in the transverse direction there is no significant restriction because L is large. The vacuum energy between the plates, in volume L^2a, is

$$E(a) = \hbar c \int \frac{\mathrm{d}^2k_\perp}{(2\pi/L)^2} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \sqrt{k_\perp^2 + \left(\frac{n\pi}{a}\right)^2}.$$

Here $\mathrm{d}^2k_\perp/(2\pi/L)^2$ is the number of transverse modes in the element $\mathrm{d}^2k_\perp$ near $\boldsymbol{k}_\perp$.

The change in vacuum energy associated with inserting the plates into this volume is

$$\Delta E(a) = E(a) - E_0(a) = \hbar c \int \frac{\mathrm{d}^2k_\perp}{(2\pi/L)^2} \Bigg[\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \sqrt{k_\perp^2 + \left(\frac{n\pi}{a}\right)^2} - \int_0^{\infty} \mathrm{d}n \sqrt{k_\perp^2 + \left(\frac{n\pi}{a}\right)^2} \Bigg].$$

This change produces a force per unit area between the plates,

$$F(a) = -\frac{1}{L^2} \frac{\partial \Delta E(a)}{\partial a}.$$

Both $E(a)$ and $E_0(a)$ diverge (vacuum divergence), but $\Delta E(a)$ is finite. After calculation (see standard quantum-mechanics textbooks, for example those by Su Ru-Keng and Zhang Yong-De),

$$\boxed{F(a) = -\frac{\hbar c \pi^2}{240 a^4}.}$$

The attractive force caused by the change (fluctuation) in vacuum energy when the plates are inserted, and its dependence on a, were experimentally observed in 1958. This is an observable effect of the vacuum energy.

9) Time evolution of observables in the Heisenberg picture

Omitting the H subscript, the Heisenberg equations of motion give

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{a}}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{a}, \hat{H}] = -\mathrm{i}\omega\hat{a}, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{a}^\dagger}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{a}^\dagger, \hat{H}] = \mathrm{i}\omega\hat{a}^\dagger.$$

The solutions are

$$\hat{a}(t) = \hat{a}(0)e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega t}, \qquad \hat{a}^\dagger(t) = \hat{a}^\dagger(0)e^{\mathrm{i}\omega t}.$$

Alternatively,

$$\hat{x}(t) = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}}\left(\hat{a}(t) + \hat{a}^\dagger(t)\right) = \hat{x}(0)\cos\omega t + \frac{\hat{p}(0)}{m\omega}\sin\omega t,$$
$$\hat{p}(t) = \mathrm{i}\sqrt{\frac{m\hbar\omega}{2}}\left(\hat{a}^\dagger(t) - \hat{a}(t)\right) = \hat{p}(0)\cos\omega t - m\omega\hat{x}(0)\sin\omega t.$$

Although $\hat{x}(t)$ and $\hat{p}(t)$ oscillate, their expectation values in an energy eigenstate are

$$\langle n|\hat{x}(t)|n\rangle = \langle n|\hat{x}(0)|n\rangle\cos\omega t + \frac{1}{m\omega}\langle n|\hat{p}(0)|n\rangle\sin\omega t = 0,$$
$$\langle n|\hat{p}(t)|n\rangle = \langle n|\hat{p}(0)|n\rangle\cos\omega t - m\omega\langle n|\hat{x}(0)|n\rangle\sin\omega t = 0$$

and thus show no oscillation.

2.4 Coherent States of the Harmonic Oscillator

In energy eigenstates of the harmonic oscillator, the expectation values of $\hat{x}$ and $\hat{p}$ are zero, and no classical oscillation is observed. However, consider a linear combination of energy eigenstates, for example

$$|a\rangle = c_0|0\rangle + c_1|1\rangle.$$

In the Heisenberg picture, the expectation value is

$$\begin{aligned}\langle a|\hat{x}(t)|a\rangle &= (c_0^*\langle 0| + c_1^*\langle 1|)\hat{x}(t)(c_0|0\rangle + c_1|1\rangle) \\ &= c_0^*c_1\langle 0|\hat{x}(t)|1\rangle + c_1^*c_0\langle 1|\hat{x}(t)|0\rangle \\ &= \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}}\left(c_0^*c_1e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega t} + c_1^*c_0e^{\mathrm{i}\omega t}\right).\end{aligned}$$

Oscillations appear. Can one find a state whose oscillation is closest to classical oscillation, that is, the oscillation of $\hat{x}(t)$? This leads to the coherent state $|\alpha\rangle$, defined as an eigenstate of the lowering operator:

$$\boxed{\hat{a}|\alpha\rangle = \alpha|\alpha\rangle.}$$

Note that $\hat{a}$ is not Hermitian; its eigenvalue α is generally complex.

1) Coherent states satisfy the minimum-uncertainty relation

The uncertainty relation is

$$(\Delta x)^2(\Delta p)^2 \geq \frac{\hbar^2}{4}.$$

In the coherent state $|\alpha\rangle$,

$$\langle\alpha|\hat{x}|\alpha\rangle = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}}\left\langle\alpha\middle|\hat{a}^\dagger + \hat{a}\middle|\alpha\right\rangle = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}}(\alpha^* + \alpha),$$
$$\left\langle\alpha\middle|\hat{x}^2\middle|\alpha\right\rangle = \frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}[1 + (\alpha + \alpha^*)^2],$$
$$\langle\alpha|\hat{p}|\alpha\rangle = -\mathrm{i}\sqrt{\frac{\hbar m\omega}{2}}(\alpha - \alpha^*),$$
$$\left\langle\alpha\middle|\hat{p}^2\middle|\alpha\right\rangle = \frac{\hbar m\omega}{2}[1 - (\alpha - \alpha^*)^2].$$

It follows that

$$(\Delta x)^2(\Delta p)^2 = \left(\langle\hat{x}^2\rangle - \langle\hat{x}\rangle^2\right)\left(\langle\hat{p}^2\rangle - \langle\hat{p}\rangle^2\right) = \frac{\hbar^2}{4}.$$

Thus coherent states satisfy the minimum-uncertainty relation and are the quantum states closest to classical states.

2) Expansion of a coherent state

Expand $|\alpha\rangle$ in energy eigenstates:

$$|\alpha\rangle = \sum_n c_n |n\rangle .$$

Since

$$c_n = \langle n|\alpha\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{n!}}\langle 0|\hat{a}^n|\alpha\rangle = \frac{\alpha^n}{\sqrt{n!}}\langle 0|\alpha\rangle = \frac{\alpha^n}{\sqrt{n!}}c_0,$$

we have

$$|\alpha\rangle = c_0 \sum_n \frac{\alpha^n}{\sqrt{n!}}|n\rangle .$$

Normalization gives

$$1 = \langle\alpha|\alpha\rangle = \sum_n |c_n|^2 = |c_0|^2 \sum_n \frac{|\alpha|^{2n}}{n!} = |c_0|^2 e^{|\alpha|^2}.$$

Choose $c_0 = e^{-|\alpha|^2/2}$; then

$$\boxed{|\alpha\rangle = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} e^{-|\alpha|^2/2}\frac{\alpha^n}{\sqrt{n!}}|n\rangle .}$$

3) The ground state is a coherent state

For the ground state $|0\rangle$, $\hat{a}|0\rangle = 0$. Thus $|0\rangle$ is an eigenstate of the annihilation operator, with eigenvalue zero.

4) Time evolution of the eigenvalue

In the Heisenberg picture,

$$\hat{a}(t) = \hat{a}(0)e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega t},$$
$$\hat{a}(t)|\alpha\rangle = \hat{a}(0)e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega t}|\alpha\rangle = \alpha e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega t}|\alpha\rangle .$$

Hence the eigenvalue evolves as

$$\boxed{\alpha(t) = \alpha e^{-\mathrm{i}\omega t}.}$$

2.5 Schrödinger Equation in the Coordinate Representation and the WKB Approximation

Consider the abstract state $|\psi, t\rangle$, whose Schrödinger equation is

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}|\psi,t\rangle = \hat{H}|\psi,t\rangle\,.$$

Multiply from the left by the eigenbra $\langle\boldsymbol{x}|$ of the position operator $\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}$. Since these eigenstates are time independent in the Schrödinger picture,

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi,t\rangle = \left\langle\boldsymbol{x}\middle|\hat{H}\middle|\psi,t\right\rangle = \int \mathrm{d}^3x'\,\left\langle\boldsymbol{x}\middle|\hat{H}\middle|\boldsymbol{x}'\right\rangle\langle\boldsymbol{x}'|\psi,t\rangle\,.$$

Let

$$\hat{H} = \frac{\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}^2}{2m} + V(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}).$$

Since

$$\left\langle\boldsymbol{x}\middle|\hat{H}\middle|\boldsymbol{x}'\right\rangle = \delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}-\boldsymbol{x}')\left[-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m}\nabla^2 + V(\boldsymbol{x})\right],$$

we obtain

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi,t\rangle = \left[-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m}\nabla^2 + V(\boldsymbol{x})\right]\langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi,t\rangle\,.$$

Define the wavefunction $\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t) = \langle\boldsymbol{x}|\psi,t\rangle$. This is the Schrödinger equation in the coordinate representation.

1) Time-independent Schrödinger equation

Put

$$\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t) = \varphi(\boldsymbol{x})T(t).$$

If $\hat{H}$ has no time dependence, inserting this into the Schrödinger equation separates it into two equations. The time-dependent factor is

$$T(t) = e^{-\mathrm{i}Et/\hbar}.$$

The energy E and $\varphi(\boldsymbol{x})$ are determined by the other equation, the energy eigenvalue equation:

$$\boxed{\left[-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m}\nabla^2 + V(\boldsymbol{x})\right]\varphi_E(\boldsymbol{x}) = E\varphi_E(\boldsymbol{x}).}$$

A stationary state is

$$\psi_E(\boldsymbol{x},t) = \varphi_E(\boldsymbol{x})e^{-\mathrm{i}Et/\hbar}.$$

For bound states the bound-state condition

$$\lim_{|\boldsymbol{x}|\to\infty}\varphi_E(\boldsymbol{x}) = 0$$

leads to discrete values of E.

Stationary states are particular solutions when $\hat{H}$ is time independent. The general solution is a linear superposition of stationary states:

$$\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t) = \sum_E c_E\psi_E(\boldsymbol{x},t).$$

2) Probability interpretation of the wavefunction

The probability density of finding the particle at a given point is

$$\rho(\boldsymbol{x},t) = |\,\langle \boldsymbol{x}|\psi(t)\rangle\,|^2 = |\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t)|^2 = \psi^*(\boldsymbol{x},t)\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t).$$

When $V(\boldsymbol{x})$ is real, the Schrödinger equation can be written as the continuity equation,

$$\boxed{\frac{\partial \rho(\boldsymbol{x},t)}{\partial t} + \boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{x},t) = 0,}$$

$$\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{x},t) = -\frac{\mathrm{i}\hbar}{2m}\left[\psi^*(\boldsymbol{x},t)\boldsymbol{\nabla}\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t) - \psi(\boldsymbol{x},t)\boldsymbol{\nabla}\psi^*(\boldsymbol{x},t)\right].$$

What is the physical meaning of $\boldsymbol{j}$? Integrate the continuity equation over a finite volume V:

$$\int_V \mathrm{d}^3r\,\frac{\partial\rho(\boldsymbol{r},t)}{\partial t} + \int_V \mathrm{d}^3r\,\boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{r},t) = 0,$$

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\int_V \mathrm{d}^3r\,\rho(\boldsymbol{r},t) = -\oint_{\partial V}\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{S}\cdot\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{r},t).$$

Local probability conservation says that the change in the probability inside V equals the negative of the outward probability flux across its boundary S. Thus $\boldsymbol{j}$ is called the probability-current density.

If we integrate over all space,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\int_{\mathbb{R}^3} \mathrm{d}^3r\,\rho(\boldsymbol{r},t) = -\oint_{\infty}\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{S}\cdot\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{r},t) = 0.$$

Therefore $\int \mathrm{d}^3r\,\rho(\boldsymbol{r},t)$ is independent of time and is a constant. This implies:

a) Total probability is conserved; particles are neither created nor annihilated. This describes nonrelativistic quantum mechanics.

b) The normalization of a wavefunction is independent of time. Schrödinger evolution preserves normalization.

c) If V is complex, probability is not conserved, and this can effectively describe creation and annihilation of particles.

3) How does a quantum system approach a classical system?

An operator in a general state has no definite value, whereas its expectation value does. Thus expectation values of quantum observables correspond to physical quantities in classical mechanics.

The classical equation of motion is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}O}{\mathrm{d}t} = \{O,H\}_{\text{Poisson bracket}},$$

while the quantum equation of motion for the expectation value is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\langle O\rangle}{\mathrm{d}t} = \frac{\langle[\hat{O},\hat{H}]\rangle}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}.$$

In the classical limit, observables commute, and $[\hat{O},\hat{H}]\to 0$. To recover the classical equation of motion, one requires

$$\hbar \longrightarrow 0, \qquad \frac{\langle[\hat{O},\hat{H}]\rangle}{\mathrm{i}\hbar} \longrightarrow \{O,H\}_{\text{Poisson bracket}}.$$

4) WKB approximation to the time-independent equation

Only a few Schrödinger equations can be solved exactly. Expanding the Schrödinger equation in powers of $\hbar$ and solving it by successive approximations gives the WKB approximation (Wentzel, Kramers and Brillouin).

Write a stationary-state wavefunction as

$$\Psi(\boldsymbol{r},t) = \psi(\boldsymbol{r})e^{-\mathrm{i}Et/\hbar} = e^{\mathrm{i}s(\boldsymbol{r})/\hbar}e^{-\mathrm{i}Et/\hbar} = e^{\mathrm{i}[s(\boldsymbol{r})-Et]/\hbar}.$$

Insert this into the stationary Schrödinger equation,

$$\left[-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m}\nabla^2 + V(\boldsymbol{r})\right]\psi(\boldsymbol{r}) = E\psi(\boldsymbol{r}).$$

We find

$$\frac{(\boldsymbol{\nabla}s)^2}{2m} + V(\boldsymbol{r}) - E - \frac{\mathrm{i}\hbar}{2m}\nabla^2 s = 0.$$

Expand $s(\boldsymbol{r})$ in $\hbar/\mathrm{i}$:

$$s(\boldsymbol{r}) = s_0(\boldsymbol{r}) + \frac{\hbar}{\mathrm{i}}s_1(\boldsymbol{r}) + \left(\frac{\hbar}{\mathrm{i}}\right)^2 s_2(\boldsymbol{r}) + \cdots.$$

Equate like powers of $\hbar$:

$$\begin{aligned}
\hbar^0: &\quad (\boldsymbol{\nabla}s_0)^2 + 2m[V(\boldsymbol{r}) - E] = 0,\\
\hbar^1: &\quad \boldsymbol{\nabla}s_1\cdot\boldsymbol{\nabla}s_0 + \tfrac{1}{2}\nabla^2 s_0 = 0,\\
&\quad \vdots
\end{aligned}$$

For one dimension,

$$s_0(x) = \pm\int^x p(x')\mathrm{d}x' + C, \qquad s_1(x) = -\ln\sqrt{p(x)} + \widetilde{C},$$

$$\boxed{p(x) = \sqrt{2m[E - V(x)]}.}$$

Keeping terms through first order in $\hbar$,

$$\begin{aligned}
\psi_{\mathrm{II}}(x) &= \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\left(s_0(x) + \frac{\hbar}{\mathrm{i}}s_1(x)\right)\right]\\
&= \frac{C_1}{\sqrt{p(x)}}\exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\int^x p(x')\mathrm{d}x'\right) + \frac{C_2}{\sqrt{p(x)}}\exp\left(-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\int^x p(x')\mathrm{d}x'\right).
\end{aligned}$$

This solution is valid where $p(x) = \sqrt{2m[E - V(x)]} > 0$, that is, $E > V$. In classical mechanics, $E = T + V$; the condition $E > V$ therefore identifies a classically allowed region.

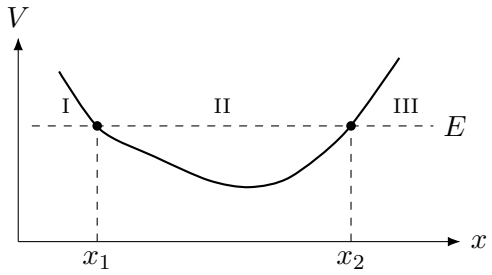
In the classically forbidden region, $E < V$, put

$$p(x) = \mathrm{i}\widetilde{p}(x) = \mathrm{i}\sqrt{2m[V(x) - E]}.$$

Then

$$\psi_{\mathrm{I,III}}(x) = \frac{C_3}{\sqrt{|p(x)|}}\exp\left(\frac{1}{\hbar}\int^x \widetilde{p}(x')\mathrm{d}x'\right) + \frac{C_4}{\sqrt{|p(x)|}}\exp\left(-\frac{1}{\hbar}\int^x \widetilde{p}(x')\mathrm{d}x'\right).$$

At $E = V$, the momentum $p = 0$ and the solution diverges: WKB is no longer valid. A point x_0 satisfying $E - V(x_0) = 0$ is a classical turning point. How can one solve the equation near x_0?



Expand the potential to linear order near x_0:

$$V(x) \simeq V(x_0) + \left.\frac{\mathrm{d}V}{\mathrm{d}x}\right|_{x_0} (x - x_0).$$

Substitution into the stationary Schrödinger equation gives

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}^2\varphi}{\mathrm{d}x^2} - \frac{2m}{\hbar^2} \left.\frac{\mathrm{d}V}{\mathrm{d}x}\right|_{x_0} (x - x_0)\varphi = 0.$$

The exact solutions are Bessel functions of order $\pm\frac{1}{3}$. Consider their asymptotic solutions when $|x - x_0|$ is large and require continuity with the classically allowed and forbidden solutions on either side of x_0. In this way the constants C_1, C_2, C_3, C_4 can be fixed.

2.6 Feynman Path Integral

1) Propagator in the Schrödinger picture

Start with the time evolution of the state:

$$|\psi, t\rangle = e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} |\psi, t_0\rangle .$$

In the coordinate representation,

$$\begin{aligned} \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \psi, t\rangle &= \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, |\psi, t_0\rangle \\ &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x' \, \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, |\boldsymbol{x}'\rangle \langle \boldsymbol{x}' | \psi, t_0\rangle . \end{aligned}$$

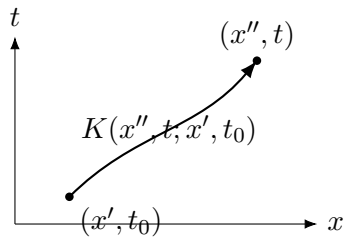
Define the matrix element of the evolution operator,

$$\boxed{K(\boldsymbol{x}'', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0) = \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, |\boldsymbol{x}'\rangle .}$$

Then

$$\psi(\boldsymbol{x}'', t) = \int \mathrm{d}^3x' \, K(\boldsymbol{x}'', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0)\psi(\boldsymbol{x}', t_0).$$

The function $K(\boldsymbol{x}'', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0)$ is the propagator: it propagates the initial wavefunction $\psi(\boldsymbol{x}', t_0)$ to the final wavefunction $\psi(\boldsymbol{x}'', t)$. Integration means that every possible position of the particle in the initial wavefunction contributes to its final state.



We now derive the propagator's relationship to the equation of motion. Take $t \geq t_0$ and define a related propagator incorporating the initial condition:

$$K(\boldsymbol{x}'', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0) = \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, | \boldsymbol{x}' \rangle \; \theta(t - t_0).$$

Differentiate with respect to t:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathrm{i}\hbar \frac{\partial K}{\partial t} &= \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, \hat{H} e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, | \boldsymbol{x}' \rangle \, \theta(t - t_0) \\
&\quad + \mathrm{i}\hbar \, \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, | \boldsymbol{x}' \rangle \, \delta(t - t_0) \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}^3 x''' \, \left\langle \boldsymbol{x}'' \middle| \hat{H} \middle| \boldsymbol{x}''' \right\rangle K(\boldsymbol{x}''', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0) \\
&\quad + \mathrm{i}\hbar \delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}'' - \boldsymbol{x}') \delta(t - t_0) \\
&= \hat{H}(\boldsymbol{x}'') K(\boldsymbol{x}'', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0) + \mathrm{i}\hbar \delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}'' - \boldsymbol{x}') \delta(t - t_0).
\end{aligned}$$

Thus

$$\boxed{\left(\mathrm{i}\hbar \frac{\partial}{\partial t} - \hat{H}(\boldsymbol{x}'') \right) K(\boldsymbol{x}'', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0) = \mathrm{i}\hbar \delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{x}'' - \boldsymbol{x}') \delta(t - t_0).}$$

Notice that taking the spatial trace of the propagator yields

$$\begin{aligned}
\int \mathrm{d}^3 x \, K(\boldsymbol{x}, t; \boldsymbol{x}, 0) &= \int \mathrm{d}^3 x \; \langle \boldsymbol{x} | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}t/\hbar} \, | \boldsymbol{x} \rangle \\
&= \sum_E \int \mathrm{d}^3 x \; \langle \boldsymbol{x} | E \rangle \, \langle E | \boldsymbol{x} \rangle \; e^{-\mathrm{i}Et/\hbar} \\
&= \sum_E e^{-\mathrm{i}Et/\hbar}.
\end{aligned}$$

With the imaginary-time substitution $t = -\mathrm{i}\hbar\beta$, this becomes the statistical-mechanical partition function $Z = \sum_E e^{-\beta E}$, showing a relation between imaginary-time propagators and statistical mechanics.

Example 1: propagator of a one-dimensional free particle.

$$\begin{aligned}
K(x'', t; x', t_0) &= \langle x'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, | x' \rangle \\
&= \int \mathrm{d}p \; \langle x'' | p \rangle \, e^{-\mathrm{i}p^2(t-t_0)/(2m\hbar)} \, \langle p | x' \rangle \\
&= \int \frac{\mathrm{d}p}{2\pi\hbar} \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar} \left(p(x'' - x') - \frac{p^2(t - t_0)}{2m} \right) \right] \\
&= \sqrt{\frac{m}{2\pi\mathrm{i}\hbar(t - t_0)}} \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}m(x'' - x')^2}{2\hbar(t - t_0)} \right].
\end{aligned}$$

Once this propagator is known, the time evolution of an initial plane wave (stationary state), $\psi(x', t_0) = (2\pi)^{-1} \exp\left[\mathrm{i}(px' - p^2 t_0/(2m))/\hbar\right]$, is

$$\psi(x'', t) = \int \mathrm{d}x' \, K(x'', t; x', t_0) \psi(x', t_0),$$

which is again a plane wave.

Example 2: propagator of a one-dimensional harmonic oscillator.

$$\begin{aligned}
K(x'', t; x', t_0) &= \langle x'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, | x' \rangle \\
&= \sum_n \langle x'' | n \rangle \, e^{-\mathrm{i}E_n(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, \langle n | x' \rangle \\
&= \sum_n \psi_n(x'') \psi_n^*(x') e^{-\mathrm{i}E_n(t-t_0)/\hbar}.
\end{aligned}$$

Here E_n and $\psi_n(x)$ are the oscillator's energies and its coordinate-representation wavefunctions.

2) Transition amplitude in the Heisenberg picture

In the Heisenberg picture,

$$\begin{aligned} K(\boldsymbol{x}'', t; \boldsymbol{x}', t_0) &= \langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar} \, | \boldsymbol{x}' \rangle \\ &= \left(\langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}t/\hbar} \right) \left(e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{H}t_0/\hbar} \, | \boldsymbol{x}' \rangle \right) \\ &= \left(\langle \boldsymbol{x}'' | \, \hat{U}(t,0) \right) \left(\hat{U}^\dagger(t_0,0) \, | \boldsymbol{x}' \rangle \right) = \langle \boldsymbol{x}'', t | \boldsymbol{x}', t_0 \rangle \, . \end{aligned}$$

This is the amplitude for the position eigenstate $|\boldsymbol{x}', t_0\rangle$ at time t_0 to make a transition to the position eigenstate $|\boldsymbol{x}'', t\rangle$ at time t. Thus the propagator is also called a transition amplitude.

The completeness relation in the Heisenberg picture must involve basis states at the same time:

$$\int \mathrm{d}^3x \; |\boldsymbol{x}, t\rangle \, \langle \boldsymbol{x}, t| = \mathbf{1}.$$

It follows that

$$\begin{aligned} K(\boldsymbol{x}_3, t_3; \boldsymbol{x}_1, t_1) &= \langle \boldsymbol{x}_3, t_3 | \boldsymbol{x}_1, t_1 \rangle \\ &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x_2 \; \langle \boldsymbol{x}_3, t_3 | \boldsymbol{x}_2, t_2 \rangle \, \langle \boldsymbol{x}_2, t_2 | \boldsymbol{x}_1, t_1 \rangle \\ &= \int \mathrm{d}^3x_2 \, K(\boldsymbol{x}_3, t_3; \boldsymbol{x}_2, t_2) K(\boldsymbol{x}_2, t_2; \boldsymbol{x}_1, t_1), \quad t_3 > t_2 > t_1. \end{aligned}$$

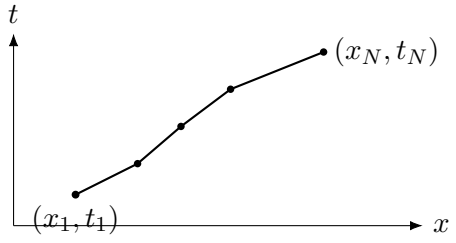
This is the composition law of propagators: propagation from $(\boldsymbol{x}_1, t_1)$ to $(\boldsymbol{x}_3, t_3)$ is the sum over propagation first to $(\boldsymbol{x}_2, t_2)$ and then to $(\boldsymbol{x}_3, t_3)$.

For simplicity, consider one spatial dimension. Divide the interval from the initial to final time into $N-1$ equal parts:

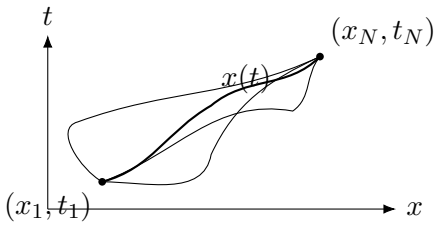
$$\mathrm{d}t = \frac{t_N - t_1}{N-1}.$$

The full propagator is

$$\begin{aligned} K(x_N, t_N; x_1, t_1) = \int & \mathrm{d}x_{N-1} \mathrm{d}x_{N-2} \cdots \mathrm{d}x_2 \; K(x_N, t_N; x_{N-1}, t_{N-1}) \\ & \times K(x_{N-1}, t_{N-1}; x_{N-2}, t_{N-2}) \cdots K(x_2, t_2; x_1, t_1). \end{aligned}$$



As $N \to \infty$, or $\mathrm{d}t \to 0$, this multiple integral becomes a sum over paths.



Unlike quantum mechanics, where every path contributes to evolution in space-time, in classical mechanics a particular initial and final state is connected by a unique path determined by the principle of least action. For example, the unique path of free fall is

$$x = h - \frac{1}{2}gt^2,$$

where h is the height and g the acceleration of gravity.

3) Path integral

The basic postulate of Feynman's path-integral theory is that the probability amplitude for propagation from (x_1, t_1) to (x_N, t_N) is the sum of contributions from all possible paths $x(t)$:

$$\boxed{K(x_N, t_N; x_1, t_1) = C \int_{x_1}^{x_N} [\mathrm{d}x(t)]\, e^{\mathrm{i}S[x(t)]/\hbar} = C \int_{x_1}^{x_N} [\mathrm{d}x(t)] \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\int_{t_1}^{t_N} L_c(x, \dot{x})\mathrm{d}t\right].}$$

The contribution of each path is $Ce^{\mathrm{i}S[x(t)]/\hbar}$. The action is

$$S[x(t)] = \int_{t_1}^{t_N} L_c(x, \dot{x})\mathrm{d}t, \qquad L_c = \frac{1}{2}m\dot{x}^2 - V(x).$$

To return the path integral to a multiple integral, take $\mathrm{d}t = (t_N - t_1)/N$ and obtain

$$K(x_N, t_N; x_1, t_1) = C \lim_{N\to\infty} \int \mathrm{d}x_{N-1} \cdots \mathrm{d}x_2 \, \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\sum_{n=2}^{N} L_c(x_n, \dot{x}_n)\mathrm{d}t\right].$$

If L_c is quadratic in x, the path integral is Gaussian and exactly integrable. For example, for a free particle,

$$L_c = \frac{1}{2}m\dot{x}^2, \qquad L_c(x_n, \dot{x}_n)\mathrm{d}t = \frac{1}{2}m\left(\frac{x_n - x_{n-1}}{\mathrm{d}t}\right)^2 \mathrm{d}t = \frac{m(x_n - x_{n-1})^2}{2\mathrm{d}t}.$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned} K(x_N, t_N; x_1, t_1) &= C \lim_{N\to\infty} \int \mathrm{d}x_{N-1} \cdots \mathrm{d}x_2 \, \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}m}{2\hbar\mathrm{d}t}\sum_{n=2}^{N}(x_n - x_{n-1})^2\right] \\ &= C \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}m(x_N - x_1)^2}{2\hbar(t_N - t_1)}\right]. \end{aligned}$$

The position eigenstates' orthogonality and normalization require

$$\lim_{t_N \to t_1} K(x_N, t_N; x_1, t_1) = \langle x_N, t_1 | x_1, t_1 \rangle = \delta(x_N - x_1).$$

Thus

$$\boxed{K(x_N, t_N; x_1, t_1) = \sqrt{\frac{m}{2\pi\mathrm{i}\hbar(t_N - t_1)}} \exp\left[\frac{\mathrm{i}m(x_N - x_1)^2}{2\hbar(t_N - t_1)}\right].}$$

This agrees with the calculation in the Schrödinger picture.

As another example, for the harmonic oscillator the classical Lagrangian is

$$L_c = \frac{1}{2}m\dot{x}^2 - \frac{1}{2}m\omega^2 x^2.$$

After evaluating the Gaussian integral,

$$K(x_N,t_N;x_1,t_1)=\sqrt{\frac{m\omega}{2\pi\mathrm{i}\hbar\sin[\omega(t_N-t_1)]}}\times\exp\left\{\frac{\mathrm{i}m\omega}{2\hbar\sin[\omega(t_N-t_1)]}\left[(x_N^2+x_1^2)\cos[\omega(t_N-t_1)]-2x_1x_N\right]\right\}.$$

Discussion.

(1) The phase factor contributed by each path is different. In a classical system, when the action S_{cl} along the classical path is much greater than $\hbar$, the actions on nearby paths differ, and their contributions oscillate rapidly and cancel; the contribution from the stationary-action path remains.

(2) Only Gaussian path integrals can be evaluated exactly.

(3) In the Schrödinger picture, the probability amplitude refers to a transition of the state. In Feynman's path integral, the probability amplitude is linked to the particle's motion, namely to paths. Feynman's path-integral theory can be proved equivalent to the Schrödinger equation (see p. 122 of the original source).

(4) A merit of the path integral is that the difference from classical mechanics is apparent and easily understood. Operators and other q-numbers need not be introduced; all calculations take place using c-numbers. Path integrals are relatively cumbersome in nonrelativistic quantum mechanics, but important in gauge field theory.

2.7 Gauge Transformations

1) Quantum coherence caused by a constant potential difference

In classical mechanics, $\boldsymbol{F}=-\boldsymbol{\nabla}V(\boldsymbol{x})$, so adding a spatially independent constant to the potential produces no effect.

In quantum mechanics, suppose a particle moves in a potential $V_1(\boldsymbol{x})$. The evolution from the initial state $|\alpha,t_0\rangle$ is

$$|\alpha,t\rangle_1=e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar}\,|\alpha,t_0\rangle\,.$$

If instead the particle moves in $V_2(\boldsymbol{x},t)=V_1(\boldsymbol{x})+\Delta V(t)$, the same initial state evolves as

$$\begin{aligned}|\alpha,t\rangle_2&=e^{-\mathrm{i}\hat{H}(t-t_0)/\hbar}\exp\left[-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\int_{t_0}^{t}\Delta V(t')\mathrm{d}t'\right]|\alpha,t_0\rangle\\&=\exp\left[-\frac{\mathrm{i}}{\hbar}\int_{t_0}^{t}\Delta V(t')\mathrm{d}t'\right]|\alpha,t\rangle_1\,.\end{aligned}$$

The two states differ by a phase factor $e^{\mathrm{i}(\varphi_2-\varphi_1)}$:

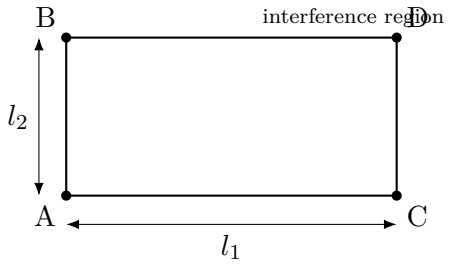
$$\varphi_2-\varphi_1=-\frac{1}{\hbar}\int_{t_0}^{t}\Delta V(t')\mathrm{d}t'\quad\xrightarrow{\Delta V\text{ constant}}\quad-\frac{\Delta V}{\hbar}(t-t_0).$$

This may seem not to lead to any measurable result. However, interference between the two wavefunctions has a term $\cos(\varphi_2-\varphi_1)$ that depends on the phase difference and is observable.

2) Quantum coherence caused by a gravitational potential difference

Consider the motion of thermal neutrons (uncharged) in a gravitational field.

At point A, the neutron beam is split into two: one travels through A–C–D to D, the other through A–B–D to D. If the frame ABCD is parallel to the ground, the two beams experience the same gravitational potential, and there is no relative gravitational phase at D.



If the frame is rotated upward by an angle δ around AC, the particle in the BD segment has a constant potential difference relative to AC:

$$\Delta V = mgl_2 \sin\delta.$$

Although the AB and CD segments also have a gravitational potential difference from AC that depends on spatial position, their contributions are the same along both paths and do not affect the relative phase. Let the neutron's travel time from B to D be T. The resulting phase difference at D is

$$\varphi_{ABD} - \varphi_{ACD} = -\frac{m}{\hbar} gl_2 T \sin\delta.$$

Since $T = l_1/v$, where v is the neutron (wavepacket) velocity, and $mv = p = \hbar/\lambda$ with λ the de Broglie wavelength in the source's convention, we have $T = l_1 m\lambda/\hbar$ and

$$\boxed{\varphi_{ABD} - \varphi_{ACD} = -\left(\frac{m}{\hbar}\right)^2 gl_1 l_2 \lambda \sin\delta.}$$

As the angle δ changes, the interference term $\cos(\varphi_{ABD} - \varphi_{ACD})$ oscillates. Such oscillations have indeed been observed experimentally (see Fig. 2.6 in the source).

This discussion shows that a spatially uniform potential difference may leave the force unchanged while producing a quantum-interference effect.

3) Gauge transformations in electromagnetism

Scalar and vector potentials:

$$\varphi(\boldsymbol{x}, t), \qquad \boldsymbol{A}(\boldsymbol{x}, t).$$

Fields:

$$\boldsymbol{E} = -\boldsymbol{\nabla}\varphi - \frac{1}{c}\frac{\partial \boldsymbol{A}}{\partial t}, \qquad \boldsymbol{B} = \boldsymbol{\nabla} \times \boldsymbol{A}.$$

From the Hamiltonian of classical electrodynamics, the quantum Hamiltonian of a charged particle in an electromagnetic field is

$$\boxed{\hat{H} = \frac{1}{2m}\left(\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} - \frac{e}{c}\boldsymbol{A}\right)^2 + e\varphi, \quad \varphi = \varphi(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, t),\ \boldsymbol{A} = \boldsymbol{A}(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}, t).}$$

Using the fundamental commutation relations

$$[\hat{x}_i, \hat{x}_j] = [\hat{p}_i, \hat{p}_j] = 0, \qquad [\hat{x}_i, \hat{p}_j] = \mathrm{i}\hbar\delta_{ij},$$

we have

$$\left[\hat{p}_i - \frac{e}{c}A_i, \hat{p}_j - \frac{e}{c}A_j\right] = \frac{\mathrm{i}\hbar e}{c}\epsilon_{ijk}B_k.$$

The Heisenberg equation of motion is

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{x}_i}{\mathrm{d}t} &= \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}[\hat{x}_i, \hat{H}] \\ &= \frac{1}{2mi\hbar}\left[\hat{x}_i, \left(\hat{p}_j - \frac{e}{c}A_j\right)\left(\hat{p}_j - \frac{e}{c}A_j\right)\right] \\ &= \frac{1}{m}\left(\hat{p}_i - \frac{e}{c}A_i\right).\end{aligned}$$

Consequently,

$$\begin{aligned}m\frac{\mathrm{d}^2\hat{x}_i}{\mathrm{d}t^2} &= \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\left(\hat{p}_i - \frac{e}{c}A_i\right) \\ &= \frac{1}{\mathrm{i}\hbar}\left[\hat{p}_i - \frac{e}{c}A_i, \hat{H}\right] - \frac{e}{c}\frac{\partial A_i}{\partial t} \\ &= \frac{e}{2mc}\epsilon_{ijk}\left(\hat{p}_j - \frac{e}{c}A_j\right)B_k - \frac{e}{2mc}\epsilon_{ijk}B_j\left(\hat{p}_k - \frac{e}{c}A_k\right) + eE_i.\end{aligned}$$

In vector notation,

$$\boxed{m\frac{\mathrm{d}^2\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}}{\mathrm{d}t^2} = e\left[\boldsymbol{E} + \frac{1}{2c}\left(\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}}{\mathrm{d}t}\times\boldsymbol{B} - \boldsymbol{B}\times\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}}{\mathrm{d}t}\right)\right].}$$

This is the Ehrenfest theorem in the Heisenberg picture. Note that the velocity operator $\mathrm{d}\hat{\boldsymbol{x}}/\mathrm{d}t$ and $\boldsymbol{B} = \boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A}$ generally do not commute; operator ordering matters in this expression.

In the coordinate representation of the Schrödinger picture,

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t)}{\partial t} = \left[\frac{1}{2m}\left(-\mathrm{i}\hbar\boldsymbol{\nabla} - \frac{e}{c}\boldsymbol{A}(\boldsymbol{x},t)\right)^2 + e\varphi(\boldsymbol{x},t)\right]\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t).$$

The continuity equation is

$$\frac{\partial\rho(\boldsymbol{x},t)}{\partial t} + \boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{x},t) = 0,$$

where

$$\rho(\boldsymbol{x},t) = |\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t)|^2,$$

$$\boldsymbol{j}(\boldsymbol{x},t) = \frac{\hbar}{m}\,\mathrm{Im}\left[\psi^*(\boldsymbol{x},t)\left(\boldsymbol{\nabla} - \frac{\mathrm{i}e}{\hbar c}\boldsymbol{A}(\boldsymbol{x},t)\right)\psi(\boldsymbol{x},t)\right].$$

Now transform the potentials as

$$\varphi(\boldsymbol{x},t) \longrightarrow \varphi(\boldsymbol{x},t), \qquad \boldsymbol{A}(\boldsymbol{x},t) \longrightarrow \boldsymbol{A}(\boldsymbol{x},t) + \boldsymbol{\nabla}\Lambda(\boldsymbol{x}),$$

where $\Lambda(\boldsymbol{x})$ is an arbitrary scalar function. It is clear that the fields $\boldsymbol{E}$ and $\boldsymbol{B}$ remain unchanged. A transformation of potentials leaving the field strengths unchanged is called a *gauge transformation*; distinct functions $\Lambda(\boldsymbol{x})$ specify different gauges.

Let the state corresponding to the potentials $\varphi, \boldsymbol{A}$ be $|\psi,t\rangle_1$, and that corresponding to $\varphi, \boldsymbol{A}+\boldsymbol{\nabla}\Lambda$ be $|\psi,t\rangle_2$. They satisfy respectively

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}|\psi,t\rangle_1 = \left[\frac{(\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} - e\boldsymbol{A}/c)^2}{2m} + e\varphi\right]|\psi,t\rangle_1,$$

$$\mathrm{i}\hbar\frac{\partial}{\partial t}|\psi,t\rangle_2 = \left[\frac{[\hat{\boldsymbol{p}} - e(\boldsymbol{A}+\boldsymbol{\nabla}\Lambda)/c]^2}{2m} + e\varphi\right]|\psi,t\rangle_2.$$

Take

$$|\psi,t\rangle_2 = \exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}e}{\hbar c}\Lambda(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}})\right)|\psi,t\rangle_1.$$

Because

$$e^{-\mathrm{i}e\Lambda/(\hbar c)}\left[\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}-\frac{e}{c}(\boldsymbol{A}+\boldsymbol{\nabla}\Lambda)\right]e^{\mathrm{i}e\Lambda/(\hbar c)}=\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}-\frac{e}{c}\boldsymbol{A},$$

it is easy to show that the two Schrödinger equations are consistent. Thus, under a gauge transformation the states differ by a phase factor:

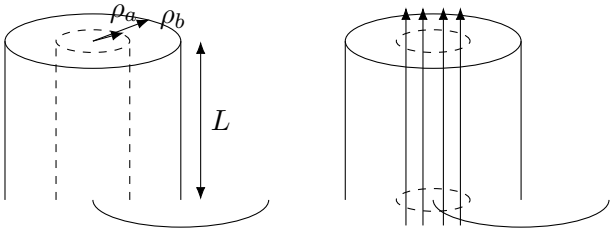
$$\boxed{|\psi,t\rangle\longrightarrow\exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}e}{\hbar c}\Lambda(\hat{\boldsymbol{x}})\right)|\psi,t\rangle\,.}$$

Does a gauge transformation have observable quantum effects?

4) Aharonov–Bohm (AB) effect

Consider a long hollow cylindrical shell with inner radius ρ_a and outer radius ρ_b. The particle moves in the shell $\rho_a<\rho<\rho_b$; it cannot enter $\rho<\rho_a$ or $\rho>\rho_b$. The wavefunction vanishes at $\rho=\rho_a$ and $\rho=\rho_b$, so this is a bound-state problem.

Now place a long solenoid in the central hollow region, with its magnetic field confined inside the solenoid, ensuring that the field outside vanishes.



Assume

$$\boldsymbol{B}=\begin{cases}0, & \rho>\rho_a,\\ B\boldsymbol{e}_z, & \rho<\rho_a.\end{cases}$$

In cylindrical coordinates,

$$\boldsymbol{B}=\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A}=\frac{1}{\rho}\begin{vmatrix}\boldsymbol{e}_\rho & \rho\boldsymbol{e}_\phi & \boldsymbol{e}_z\\ \partial/\partial\rho & \partial/\partial\phi & \partial/\partial z\\ A_\rho & \rho A_\phi & A_z\end{vmatrix}.$$

One finds

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{A}=\begin{cases}\dfrac{B\rho_a^2}{2\rho}\boldsymbol{e}_\phi, & \rho>\rho_a,\\ \dfrac{B\rho}{2}\boldsymbol{e}_\phi, & \rho<\rho_a.\end{cases}}$$

Introducing the field into the region $\rho<\rho_a$ changes the vector potential in the particle's accessible region $\rho_a<\rho<\rho_b$ from $\boldsymbol{A}=0$ to $\boldsymbol{A}\neq 0$, while the magnetic field there remains $\boldsymbol{B}=0$.

The stationary Schrödinger equation is

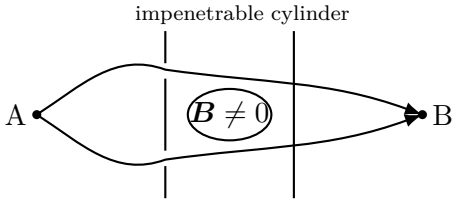
$$\frac{1}{2m}\left(\hat{\boldsymbol{p}}-\frac{e}{c}\boldsymbol{A}\right)^2\psi=-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m}\left[\boldsymbol{e}_\rho\frac{\partial}{\partial\rho}+\frac{\boldsymbol{e}_\phi}{\rho}\left(\frac{\partial}{\partial\phi}-\frac{\mathrm{i}eB\rho_a^2}{2\hbar c}\right)+\boldsymbol{e}_z\frac{\partial}{\partial z}\right]^2\psi=E\psi,\quad \rho_a<\rho<\rho_b.$$

Clearly, the magnetic-field term changes the particle's bound-state energies E. Crucially, the magnetic field $\boldsymbol{B}$ is absent from the particle's accessible region, while $\boldsymbol{A}$ is present there. In classical mechanics the motion of a charged particle is determined by $\boldsymbol{E}$ and $\boldsymbol{B}$, whereas in

quantum mechanics a potential without a field strength can still influence the properties of a system. This is a purely quantum effect.

The above is the influence of the AB effect on a bound-state problem.

Now consider the AB effect using the path integral. A charged particle starts at A and passes through two slits in a screen to reach B, where interference occurs. A long solenoid lies between the two slits behind the screen. The magnetic field is inside the solenoid and vanishes outside. For the classical system, the field inside the solenoid cannot affect the interference at B.



For a quantum system, although the field vanishes outside the solenoid, $\boldsymbol{A} \neq 0$. The action in the path integral is written in the source as

$$\begin{aligned} S[\boldsymbol{x}(t)] &= \int_{t_A}^{t_B} \mathrm{d}t \, \frac{1}{2m} \left(\boldsymbol{p} - \frac{e}{c} \boldsymbol{A} \right)^2 \\ &\simeq \int_{t_A}^{t_B} \mathrm{d}t \left[\frac{m}{2} \left(\frac{\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}}{\mathrm{d}t} \right)^2 - \frac{e}{c} \frac{\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}}{\mathrm{d}t} \cdot \boldsymbol{A} \right] \\ &= S_0[\boldsymbol{x}(t)] - \frac{e}{c} \int_{t_A}^{t_B} \mathrm{d}t \, \frac{\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}}{\mathrm{d}t} \cdot \boldsymbol{A} = S_0[\boldsymbol{x}(t)] - \frac{e}{c} \int_{\boldsymbol{x}_A}^{\boldsymbol{x}_B} \boldsymbol{A} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x}. \end{aligned}$$

The source neglects the term quadratic in $\boldsymbol{A}$. For any path above the solenoid and any path below it, the two contributions to the amplitude $K(\boldsymbol{x}_B, t_B; \boldsymbol{x}_A, t_A)$ have the form

$$\begin{aligned} &\exp \left[-\frac{\mathrm{i}e}{\hbar c} \int_{\boldsymbol{x}_A, \, \text{above}}^{\boldsymbol{x}_B} \boldsymbol{A} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x} \right] e^{\mathrm{i}S_0[\boldsymbol{x}_{\text{above}}(t)]/\hbar} \\ &\quad + \exp \left[-\frac{\mathrm{i}e}{\hbar c} \int_{\boldsymbol{x}_A, \, \text{below}}^{\boldsymbol{x}_B} \boldsymbol{A} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x} \right] e^{\mathrm{i}S_0[\boldsymbol{x}_{\text{below}}(t)]/\hbar}. \end{aligned}$$

There is a relative phase that affects the interference fringes:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{e}{\hbar c} \left[\int_{\text{above}} \boldsymbol{A} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x} - \int_{\text{below}} \boldsymbol{A} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x} \right] &= \frac{e}{\hbar c} \oint \boldsymbol{A} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{x} \\ &= \frac{e}{\hbar c} \int (\boldsymbol{\nabla} \times \boldsymbol{A}) \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{S} \\ &= \frac{e}{\hbar c} \int \boldsymbol{B} \cdot \mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{S} = \frac{e}{\hbar c} B \pi R^2. \end{aligned}$$

This is independent of the precise paths; Stokes' theorem has been used.

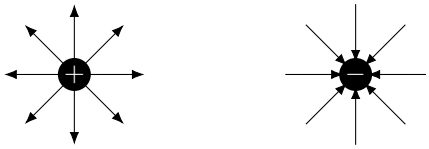
The AB effect shows that in quantum mechanics, even when the field strength vanishes, a nonzero potential can influence the interference of particles.

5) Magnetic monopoles

In classical electromagnetic theory, static electric and magnetic fields are asymmetric. The static electric field has sources but no curl:

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla} \cdot \boldsymbol{E} = 4\pi \rho_e, \qquad \boldsymbol{\nabla} \times \boldsymbol{E} = 0.$$

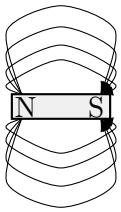
Electric field-line patterns (single-charge configuration):



The static magnetic field has no sources and does have curl:

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot\boldsymbol{B}=0,\qquad \boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{B}=\frac{4\pi}{c}\boldsymbol{J}.$$

The magnetic field-line pattern has a dipole structure:



Question: Can there be an isolated magnetic charge, that is, a magnetic monopole?

Dirac string. If there is a magnetic charge e_m at the origin, the static field it produces satisfies

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot\boldsymbol{B}=4\pi e_m\delta^{(3)}(\boldsymbol{r}).$$

Its solution is

$$\boxed{\boldsymbol{B}(\boldsymbol{r})=\frac{e_m}{r^2}\boldsymbol{e}_r.}$$

Can a vector potential $\boldsymbol{A}(\boldsymbol{r})$ be found such that the original relation $\boldsymbol{B}=\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A}$ still holds everywhere? The answer is no.

Proof: If $\boldsymbol{B}=\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A}$, then necessarily

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot\boldsymbol{B}=\boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot(\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A})=0,$$

contradicting the monopole source equation.

Likewise, by Gauss's theorem, for a closed surface surrounding the monopole,

$$\oint\boldsymbol{B}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{S}=4\pi e_m.$$

But if $\boldsymbol{B}=\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A}$, then

$$\oint\boldsymbol{B}\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{S}=\oint(\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A})\cdot\mathrm{d}\boldsymbol{S}=\int\boldsymbol{\nabla}\cdot(\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A})\mathrm{d}V=0,$$

contradicting Gauss's theorem. Thus no single globally regular vector potential $\boldsymbol{A}(\boldsymbol{r})$ can produce $\boldsymbol{B}(\boldsymbol{r})=\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A}$.

For example, in spherical coordinates take

$$\boldsymbol{A}=e_m\frac{1-\cos\theta}{r\sin\theta}\boldsymbol{e}_\varphi.$$

For $\theta<\pi-\varepsilon$ (ε infinitesimal), using

$$\begin{aligned}\boldsymbol{\nabla}\times\boldsymbol{A}=&\frac{1}{r\sin\theta}\left[\frac{\partial}{\partial\theta}(A_\varphi\sin\theta)-\frac{\partial A_\theta}{\partial\varphi}\right]\boldsymbol{e}_r\\&+\frac{1}{r}\left[\frac{1}{\sin\theta}\frac{\partial A_r}{\partial\varphi}-\frac{\partial}{\partial r}(rA_\varphi)\right]\boldsymbol{e}_\theta\\&+\frac{1}{r}\left[\frac{\partial}{\partial r}(rA_\theta)-\frac{\partial A_r}{\partial\theta}\right]\boldsymbol{e}_\varphi=\frac{e_m}{r^2}\boldsymbol{e}_r=\boldsymbol{B}.\end{aligned}$$

However, $\boldsymbol{A}$ diverges at $\theta = \pi$. The negative z axis therefore contains a singular string, called the Dirac string. Its singular contribution means that the distributional curl of this globally extended singular potential does not equal the monopole field alone.

Quantization of electric charge. Although a single vector potential satisfying $\boldsymbol{B} = \boldsymbol{\nabla} \times \boldsymbol{A}$ cannot cover all space, such potentials can be found in separate regions. For example, take

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} \boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{I}} &= e_m \frac{1-\cos\theta}{r\sin\theta}\boldsymbol{e}_\varphi, \qquad \theta < \pi - \varepsilon, \\ \boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{II}} &= -e_m \frac{1+\cos\theta}{r\sin\theta}\boldsymbol{e}_\varphi, \qquad \theta > \varepsilon. \end{aligned}}$$

$\boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{I}}$ diverges at $\theta = \pi$, while $\boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{II}}$ diverges at $\theta = 0$. With this choice of potentials,

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla} \times \boldsymbol{A} = \frac{e_m}{r^2}\boldsymbol{e}_r = \boldsymbol{B}$$

in each nonsingular region.

In their overlap, since both potentials produce the same magnetic field, they are related by a gauge transformation Λ:

$$\boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{II}} - \boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{I}} = -\frac{2e_m}{r\sin\theta}\boldsymbol{e}_\varphi = \boldsymbol{\nabla}\Lambda.$$

In spherical coordinates,

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla}\Lambda = \frac{\partial\Lambda}{\partial r}\boldsymbol{e}_r + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial\Lambda}{\partial\theta}\boldsymbol{e}_\theta + \frac{1}{r\sin\theta}\frac{\partial\Lambda}{\partial\varphi}\boldsymbol{e}_\varphi.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\Lambda(\boldsymbol{r}) = -2e_m\varphi.}$$

Consider a particle of electric charge e moving in the monopole field. The wavefunctions ψ_{I} and ψ_{II} corresponding to $\boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{I}}$ and $\boldsymbol{A}_{\mathrm{II}}$ satisfy in the overlapping region

$$\psi_{\mathrm{II}} = e^{\mathrm{i}e\Lambda/(\hbar c)}\psi_{\mathrm{I}} = e^{-2\mathrm{i}ee_m\varphi/(\hbar c)}\psi_{\mathrm{I}}.$$

By single-valuedness of the wavefunction, ψ_{II} must be single valued in the overlap. For example, at $\theta = \pi/2$,

$$\psi_{\mathrm{II}}(r, \theta = \pi/2, \varphi = 0) = \psi_{\mathrm{II}}(r, \theta = \pi/2, \varphi = 2\pi).$$

Consequently,

$$\frac{2ee_m}{\hbar c} = \pm n, \qquad n = 0, \pm 1, \pm 2, \ldots.$$

This is electric-charge quantization:

$$\boxed{e = \pm\frac{\hbar c}{2e_m}n.}$$

There is a smallest unit of electric charge.